NO. 134 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

FRIDAY 16 OCTOBER 2026



ELEVEN DAYS OF SMOKE, AND NOBODY HAS BEEN FINED FOR ANY OF IT (P5)

SINGAPORE

The central index reached 219 on Friday, past the Haze Act's threshold

THE WORLD

Unknown projectiles sank Singapore's GFS Pride; Iran blames a mine

TECHNOLOGY

Japan will fund two New York fabs; GlobalFoundries will run them

Twelve Desks · One World

Source: AFP. Visitors at the Supertree Grove, Gardens by the Bay, photographed on 8 October 2026, when the central 24-hour index stood at 181. By 5am on the 16th it read 219. Cropped; no other alteration.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 134

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THE SPINE: THE UNCLAIMED — a ship with no attacker, fires with no arsonist, a cap nobody imposed, a cartridge with nobody's name on it.

FROM THE DESK

"There's an old saying that victory has 100 fathers and defeat is an orphan..."

John F. Kennedy, 21 April 1961, accepting sole responsibility for the Bay of Pigs[1]

Kennedy said it while doing the rarer thing: putting his name to a failure. This issue is the negative of that. A Singapore-flagged ship lies on the bottom of the Hormuz strait and nobody has said they fired. Quoted as cynicism about success, the line reads the other way round as a standard: somebody owned the orphan.

THE STRIP · AT THURSDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.750%	▼ 6bp
US 10-year[2]	5.074%	▼ 11bp
VWRA	$191.48	▼ 0.16%
Global agg	$5.77	▲ 0.52%
DXY	101.98	▼ 0.56%
USD/SGD	1.2822	▼ 0.24%
Brent	$105.73	▼ 0.31%
Gold, spot	$4,170.81	▲ 1.59%
Bitcoin	$82,077	▲ 0.50%

The Straits Times Index closed 5,403.50, down 0.37%, on a day the Kospi fell 7.57% (p14). Not advice.[2]

THE MERIDIAN INDEX

21 — crew off the GFS Pride before she sank — p3

0 — parties claiming the attack — p3

19,000,000 v 2,900,000 — barrels a day through Hormuz, per two counts — p3

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300 — the index at which schools would shut — p13

540,000,000 — cartridges from the Hungarian firm — p6

€268 — the surcharge for gold plating — p6

$21,000,000,000 — Japanese money, two New York fabs — p7

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3 in 4 — tries a $5,900 laptop shut itself off — p9

4 — days from five-star review to release — p11

£20,000,000 — cover a British caver buys for £32 — p15

980,000 v 1,336 — eligible, and registered — p21

SOURCES 1 The remark as carried in a New York public broadcaster's archive of 21 April 1961, read at source, on the day Kennedy accepted sole responsibility for the Bay of Pigs. **Kennedy himself calls it an old saying. It is widely traced to Count Galeazzo Ciano's wartime diary, and this desk could not verify that attribution at source — so it is noted as a tracing, not asserted. Some accounts render the figure as a thousand; the hundred is what the archive quotes.** 2 Levels as set out and sourced on the Macro Desk (p14): Treasury yields at Thursday's settlement; equity, bond, currency, commodity and bitcoin levels at the close of 15 October from market-data interfaces queried directly; gold is the spot benchmark. **The Friday Asia session had not closed when this issue was set, so no Friday level appears anywhere in it.** Every figure in The Meridian Index is sourced on the page cited beside it.

THE WORLD · HORMUZ

Unknown projectiles sank Singapore's GFS Pride; Iran blames a naval mine

The Maritime and Port Authority called the 13 October strike unprovoked and a breach of international law. All 21 crew got off. It named nobody.

The Maritime and Port Authority of Singapore said on **14 October** that two Singapore-registered container ships had been struck by **"unknown projectiles"** in the Strait of Hormuz. The **GFS Pride** was hit on the 13th, caught fire and sank; her **21 crew** were evacuated without injury. Sister ship **GFS Giselle** was hit next day, took hull damage and reached anchorage under her own propulsion, **22 crew** safe. No Singaporeans were aboard.[1]

The release calls the attacks **"unprovoked, unjustifiable, and a breach of international law,"** citing **"the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea."** It is issued by the Authority as an institution: no spokesperson is named, and neither is Iran. For the flag state of a ship on the bottom, that is a carefully built sentence.[1]

The Pride was no flag of convenience. She is **IMO 9349045**, call sign **9V6902**, South Korean-built in 2008, **222 metres** by thirty, **2,824 TEU** — and her registered owner is **Coral Navigation Pte Ltd**, a Singapore company, managed from the Emirates by GFS Ship Management FZE, which Reuters could not reach. She is the **second ship to sink** since the war opened on 28 February.[2]

Tehran's account is not that it attacked her. Tasnim, close to the Revolutionary Guards, reported a box ship carrying **2,500 containers** had **exploded and sunk after hitting a naval mine** on an "unauthorised" route — the US-escorted corridor along the Omani coast, which Iran calls illegal. An unnamed Iranian naval officer put it flatly on the 15th: **"The Strait of Hormuz is closed; if it were not closed, oil would be passing through it."**[3]

SINGAPORE — THE MARITIME AND PORT AUTHORITY

The register is legal, not martial: a breach of "*international law, in particular the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea.*" No attacker, no minister, no name.[1]

WASHINGTON — US CENTRAL COMMAND

A flat contradiction of Tehran: "*American forces and regional partners clearly control the Strait of Hormuz,*" and US forces helped move **more than 19 million barrels** of crude through it the previous day.[2]

0

PARTIES THAT HAVE CLAIMED THE SINKING. IRAN SAYS SHE STRUCK A MINE; SINGAPORE SAYS UNKNOWN PROJECTILES; NOBODY HAS SAID THEY FIRED[1]

THE SCEPTIC · CLOSED IS DOING A LOT OF WORK

The firm **Marisks** finds **no independent evidence** of a mine. But the sharper dissent is not that she sank — it is that the strait is "closed." **Kpler** put Gulf flows excluding Iran above **81%** of pre-war levels in September; Vanguard's **Barun Gupta** independently at about **80%**. Against that, Al Jazeera reports only **2.9 million barrels** passed on 11 October — which sits awkwardly beside CENTCOM's nineteen-million-barrel day, because the two are almost certainly counting different things. This desk prints both rather than choosing. What would settle it: a flag-state casualty investigation, or transits back at **130 a day**.[2][4][5]

SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT

No. 133 carried Amin Nasser's **"Our system is intact"** and his twelve-million-barrel assurance inside the Dhahran story, where they read as his answer to the strike on Aramco's headquarters. They were not. Nasser said both at the **Energy Intelligence Forum in London on Monday 5 October**, eight days before the building was hit. The error was this desk's.[6]

SOURCES 1 The Maritime and Port Authority of Singapore's own release of 14 October 2026, read at source, for both vessels, both crew counts, the sinking, the "unknown projectiles" wording, the quoted characterisation and the UNCLOS reference. **The absence of a named spokesperson and of any named attacker is a property of the release itself.** 2 Reuters via a maritime trade service and a maritime news service, both read at source, for the vessel's particulars, the manager's unreachability, the IMO sinking count, the UKMTO warnings, the fatality total, the pre-war transit norm and the CENTCOM statement. Hull particulars cross-checked across three registry services. 3 A German agency report, read at source in syndication, for the Tasnim account and the routing dispute; the unnamed naval officer via a US broadcaster's live file. **Tasnim's own page was not read.** 4 An Abu Dhabi daily, 15 October, read at source, for the Marisks assessment and its refusal to verify the salvage clips. 5 Al Jazeera, 15 October, read at source, for the Kpler share and the barrel count; the Vanguard figure via a US broadcaster. **Across 13–16 October this desk found no Xinhua or Global Times item on Hormuz, oil or Iran — a same-day search of two state outlets, not a claim about their whole output.** 6 Reuters, Mukherjee and Harvey, filed 5 October 2026, read at source in syndication. **Three outlets independently date the remarks to the London forum.**

THE WORLD · BAN KEUN

China calls its new Laos air base a friendship aviation academy

Satellite imagery from 30 September shows a 6,560-foot runway thirty miles from Vientiane. Beijing says it is for pilot training. Laos has not commented.

China's Ministry of National Defence confirmed this week that it has opened an aviation facility at **Ban Keun in Laos**, about **thirty miles** from Vientiane — its first overseas air installation. Satellite imagery of **30 September**, analysed by the Associated Press, shows a runway of roughly **6,560 feet** with a parallel taxiway, an apron sized for **two dozen aircraft**, and room to lengthen the strip by **at least 3,280 feet**, which analysts say could take bombers.[1]

The ministry calls it the **"China-Laos Joint Support and Training Center and the China-Laos Friendship Aviation Academy,"** says it will **"help Laos strengthen the training of its air force pilots,"** and that it is **"not directed against any third party."** Beijing has not said whether aircraft will be permanently stationed there. **Laos did not respond** to requests for comment, and neither did Vietnam, Cambodia or Myanmar.[1]

The assessments split on now against later. The Institute for the Study of War judges it cannot yet support major combat operations but gives the PLA **"alternate routes to access disputed areas of the South China Sea."** Thailand's defence ministry spokesman, Rear Admiral **Surasant Kongsiri**, said Bangkok does not see a threat but will keep watching.[1]

WASHINGTON — CSIS

Greg Poling calls Laos a "*target of opportunity*," and China's overseas basing "*a lot more like playing roulette than poker*" — a bet placed where a partner is cheap, not where the ground is good.[1]

SINGAPORE — IISS

Evan Laksmana turns it into the awkward question for every ASEAN defence ministry: would the United States "*have to attack a joint facility in Southeast Asia?*"[1]

ALSO ON THE WIRE

Zelensky ends the refinery pause after three days. The Ukrainian president told the *Financial Times* **"The block is out. We're done,"** and would stop again only for more US **Patriot** interceptors — **"the minimum."** On what Washington asks next: **"Maybe it will be gas. Definitely it will be gas."** Hours later drones burned Rosneft's **Ryazan** refinery, about **5%** of Russian capacity; governor **Pavel Malkov** said damage was **"now being assessed."**[2]

Russia fires 39 ballistic missiles and 120 drones at Ukraine. 600,000 lose power; all three of Kyiv's heat-and-power stations hit; **17 killed**, **67 injured** on 15 October.[2]

Houthi missiles hit Aden's presidential palace. Yemen's health minister counted **five killed** and **16 injured** at al-Maashiq, including two of the prime minister's bodyguards; the prime minister was unhurt. Riyadh's airport stays shut, attacked **20 times** this month.[3]

THE CHATTER · NOBODY IS OWNING UP

Ukrainian Starshield terminals began dropping connection above a speed threshold, crippling mid-range strike drones. **Elon Musk**, replying to Mykhailo Fedorov on the 14th: **"Starshield systems are owned and controlled by the US government... Any limits on speed or usage are decided by the U.S. military and ultimately POTUS."** Junior Sergeant **Dimko Zhluktenko** of the 413th Unmanned Systems Regiment said the restriction **"came without any warning,"** costing **"tens of millions of dollars"**; a **160 km/h** cap remained next day. US officials called it a **"technical malfunction"**; the White House denied any role; the Pentagon has not explained. Senator **Thom Tillis** wants an inquiry into either **"an unacceptable error or lapse"** or **"a conscious decision to clear the field for a Russian attack."**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · A RUNWAY IS NOT A BASE

Read the imagery conservatively and Ban Keun is a training strip with a long apron. Nothing published shows **hangars, hardened shelters or stationed aircraft**, and the bomber claim rests on an extension nobody has built. The counter is stronger: a runway is the expensive part, and Beijing has never before had one outside its own territory. An option purchased, not a capability fielded. The test is whether concrete follows.[1]

SOURCES 1 A US broadcaster's report of 14 October, read at source, carrying the Associated Press analysis of 30 September imagery: the runway and taxiway dimensions, the apron capacity, the extension estimate and the bomber assessment; the Chinese defence ministry's naming of the facility and its three quoted statements; the non-responses from Laos, Vietnam, Cambodia and Myanmar; and the quoted judgements of CSIS, ISW, IISS and Thailand's defence ministry. **The imagery was not independently obtained by this desk, and no hangar or aircraft count is published.** 2 A Kyiv-based outlet, read at source, for the *Financial Times* interview and all three quotations; a Moscow-based outlet for the governor's statement and the refinery's share of capacity; the president's own figures for the barrage. 3 Al Jazeera, 15 October, read at source, for the Aden strike, both ministers' figures and the coalition statement on Riyadh airport. 4 The same Kyiv outlet for the Starshield restriction, the Musk reply, the serving soldier's account and the senators' statements; a US broadcaster, 15 October, as second outlet. **The Pentagon has issued no explanation, and this desk found none.**

SINGAPORE · THE HAZE ACT

Singapore's central PSI hit 219, past the Haze Act's threshold

Prime Minister Lawrence Wong says the government is working out which companies are responsible. In twelve years it has never fined one.

At **5am on Friday 16 October** the National Environment Agency's own machine feed recorded a 24-hour PSI of **219** in central Singapore — with **190** in the west, **189** east, **176** south and **143** north. The **Transboundary Haze Pollution Act** engages when the 24-hour index holds above **101** for a day; the band that brings the Government's own escalation into play is **200**. The air crossed it in the dark.[1]

Five days ago this desk reported the opposite: that the index had peaked at **168** and the published rung had never been reached (No. 133, p5). It has now. The west touched **212** at noon on Thursday and the centre **213** at **3am** on Friday before the 5am reading went higher still. The highest hourly reading of the year, **288**, came in the west on Wednesday, where **251** tops the scale's named bands.[2]

Prime Minister **Lawrence Wong** wrote on Thursday night that Singapore is working out which companies are responsible and may act under the Act **"where warranted,"** and that while it cannot control weather, winds or what happens beyond its borders, it **"will do everything we can to protect Singaporeans."** Minister for Sustainability and the Environment **Grace Fu** had said on Wednesday that the offer of help to Jakarta **"remains there."**[2]

Nothing has come back. Fu said Singapore had received **no update from Indonesia**, called it **"a very difficult year because of El Niño"** and said **"the issues are very complex."** The Act carries fines of **S$100,000 a day** to a **S$2 million** cap. Since it came into force in **September 2014**, no company has been fined or sued under it.[3]

219

24-HOUR PSI IN CENTRAL SINGAPORE AT 5AM ON 16 OCTOBER, READ FROM NEA'S OWN REAL-TIME FEED. FIVE DAYS AGO THIS DESK PRINTED 168[1]

AROUND THE ISLAND

ActiveSG shut its outdoor and non-air-conditioned facilities across the east and central regions on Thursday afternoon.[4]

N95 masks went out from community clubs on Wednesday; Senior Minister **Lee Hsien Loong** collected a pack at one on Thursday and told residents to mask when necessary.[4]

A Maxwell Food Centre stall drew a record S$7,911 a month in NEA's August tender data, published mid-October, against **S$7,107** in May. The next four bids: **7,486 / 7,341 / 7,138 / 7,031**.[4]

THE CHATTER · HARDWAREZONE, THURSDAY NIGHT

The forum is not arguing about blame. It is arguing about the threshold and about supply. **compro_1975**, on the school-closure line: **"talk so big, but 280 cant even forecast.... 300 then how?" coolmyth** predicts closure will be timed to the holidays. On a separate thread drawing **42 replies in about an hour**, N95s were sold out at Guardian, 7-Eleven and Shopee — **Visor9999**: **"Supply chain mismanagement, sg Govt should step up." Reddit refused this desk at every route again**, so no r/singapore sentiment appears anywhere in this issue.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · A NOTICE IS NOT A PROSECUTION

Crossing 200 does not start a case. The Act's record of nothing is usually read as timidity; the harder reading is evidentiary. Singapore must show, to a court's standard, that a named company's concession produced smoke that crossed a border — from satellite hotspots, against corporate structures not obliged to help. **Greenpeace** has named concessions containing smoke sources and is careful to say the findings **do not establish** that those companies lit fires or committed offences. That caution is the whole problem in one clause. The counter-argument is twelve years long.[36]

SOURCES 1 The National Environment Agency's real-time PSI feed, queried directly by this desk at the 05:00 reading of 16 October 2026, for all five regional 24-hour values and the PM2.5 values. **This is the agency's machine feed, not a news report.** 2 The Prime Minister's post of 15 October and the Minister's remarks of 14 October, both read at source in a Singapore outlet's reporting, for every quotation, the west and central peaks and the record hourly reading. **No ministry release carrying these words was obtainable; two regional outlets refused this desk outright.** 3 The same reporting for Indonesia's non-response and the El Niño remark; the Act's penalty scale and commencement date from a Singapore legal-affairs site, read at source. **The "never used" finding is the absence of any recorded action, consistent with Nos. 132 and 133.** 4 A Singapore news site, each item read at source and separately dated. **The hawker figure is August tender data published in October, not a 15 October auction.** 5 Two threads on a Singapore technology forum, read at source on 15 October, usernames as posted. **Reddit was unreachable by every route — both domains blocked, the search tool refusing the domain, two mirrors returning 403 and 429.** 6 Greenpeace Southeast Asia's own press material, read at source, for its position and its explicit caveat. **The outlet carrying the concession count refused this desk, so no company count is printed.**

THE ATELIER · SHOWER FITTINGS & TAPS

Italy's Fantini says only the cartridge and aerator are bought in

The Italian house has made taps at Pella since 1947. The two parts that move, wear and touch your water are the two it does not make.

Begin with the alloy, because "solid brass" is not one thing. The default hot-forging tap brass is **CW617N**, and ALMAG's datasheet disqualifies it in a sentence: **"The high lead content... means it cannot be used in contact with drinking water."** To EN 12165 that is **2.2–2.5% lead**, corrosion resistance rated **"Not resistant."** The alloy that makes a tap cheap to machine is too leaded for drinking water.[1]

Compliant makers therefore move: Kerox specifies **CW501L-DW** and **CW724R-DW** for wetted parts, and America's step from **C36000** at **3% lead** to **C69300** at **0.09%** is roughly thirtyfold. The rule that forced it cut wetted surfaces to **0.25%** from **January 2014**, now in **NSF/ANSI/CAN 372**.[2]

Then the part that actually fails. **Kerox**, of Sóskút in Hungary, has sold **540 million cartridges**. Brizo — Delta Faucet Company's luxury marque — ships genuine spare **RP75213**, listed by its distributor as **"Cartridge Assembly — Kerox K45," USD 108.58**. Kerox buys in too: its quality page admits **"outsourced metal components."** The vertical integration everyone imagines exists nowhere in this category.[3]

Singapore then legislates the ending. PUB's scheme is mandatory — **from 1 April 2019 only two-tick fittings and above may be supplied or installed** — capping a shower mixer at **7 litres a minute** and a basin at **4**. A Vola rough-in is rated **12 GPM**, about **45**. A regulator does all of that, so on flow every tier is identical by law. The water is soft — hardness **42.7 mg/L**, pH **8.0** — a chloramine city, not a limescale city, so the European worry about descaling is the wrong worry and seals and hoses are the right one.[4]

WHAT EACH STEP ACTUALLY BUYS

Entry of quality, €214 — forged body, a spares chain, a ceramic disc. The engineering argument is already won here.[5]

The grail, US$2,213 — a thicker machined body, a PVD finish, a two-month lead time. Not a longer-lived cartridge.[5]

THE CHATTER · HARDWAREZONE, AND A SILENCE

wacko finds Grohe **"nowhere near as solidly built"** as Hansgrohe and **"plasticky to the feel."** The counterweight, from **MultiSystemAtrophy**: **"I personally feel no difference, reliability the same after 7+ years."** Then **wacko** concedes what decides it: **"The basic washbasin taps do not differ much between the 2 brands."** And the local line, from **senocs**: German shops at **"around 1/3 of the price vs SG shops."** In a thread full of parallel importers, **not one word about who honours the warranty.** That silence is the purchase nobody prices.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE THEATRE IS

"Spanish cartridge" is often a Chinese one: Sedal advertises **"factories in europe and china,"** naming plants at Barcelona, **Kaiping** and **Jiangmen**. **The list price is the next prop.** At one German stocking dealer this week, shipping in 1–3 days: Dornbracht Tara **−47%**, Tara Ultra kitchen **−52%**, Grohe Grohtherm **−50%**. Prices routinely halved are not prices. **Then the finish:** Axor's V 140 is **€959** plain and **€1,228** in gold-optic — **€268 for the plating**. The curve flattens at the sweet spot; above it you buy a body, a finish and a lead time. Not longevity — the cartridge that fails is the same one.[7]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Scissors & shears — Seki and Solingen forging against stamped steel.

Sewing machines — cast iron against die-cast, and the vintage Singer trade.

Mosquito nets — denier, mesh count, and the bed a tropical flat was built around.

SOURCES 1 ALMAG SpA's own FAB CW617N datasheet (PDF), read at source, for the quoted drinking-water restriction, the EN 12165 lead range and the corrosion rating. 2 Kerox's September 2026 handbook (PDF) for the alloy designations; the Copper Development Association's database for C36000 and C69300; a chartered engineer's whitepaper for the 1986 and 2011 thresholds. All read at source. 3 Kerox's own handbook and quality page for the 540-million figure, the K-45 and the outsourced metal; a US distributor's product record for Brizo part RP75213. **The Kerox attribution is on the distributor's listing of Brizo's genuine part, corroborated by Kerox's catalogue — not from a Brizo document.** 4 PUB's own efficiency-requirements and drinking-water reports (PDFs), extracted at source; a US specialist's record for the Vola rough-in's rating. **The requirements PDF is dated 1 December 2021 and PUB's live pages returned 403, so the bands are that published schedule; the scheme itself is certainly still mandatory.** 5 A German and a US specialist's live catalogues, read at source. **Vola's trim requires a separately sold rough-in; the figure is trim plus rough.** 6 A Singapore forum thread, read at source, usernames as posted. **Reddit unreachable by every route.** 7 Sedal's own site for the quoted phrase and plant list; the same German dealer's listings for every discount and both Axor prices. **Verified Singapore stockists were each read on the stockist's own site; no Vola or Fantini dealer was found, which is the result of a search, not a statement by either maker.**

TECHNOLOGY · MALTA, NEW YORK

Japan will fund two New York fabs for GlobalFoundries to run

Tokyo provides up to $21bn; Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick takes about 4% of the operator. The first fab is due online in 2029.

GlobalFoundries announced on **14 October** that it has been selected to operate two new 300mm semiconductor fabs at its **Malta, New York** campus under a US–Japan initiative worth **"up to $21 billion"** — about **$10bn** for the first and a further **$10bn** for the second. The release states the arrangement in six words: **"Japan will provide the investment."** GlobalFoundries is **"technology provider and operator."** Its fees are not disclosed.[1]

Separately, the **US Department of Commerce** takes equity in GlobalFoundries of **"approximately four percent."** Chief executive **Tim Breen**: **"GF was selected because fabs of this scale require more than capital."** Secretary **Howard Lutnick**: **"This is how the President's trade agreements result in transformational American industrial assets."** Each fab is to add about **900,000 wafers a year**; ground is broken on the first this year and it comes online in **2029**. No process node is named.[1]

Count the flags on one building. A foreign treasury pays. Reuters reports the two governments jointly own it. An American company whose majority holder is Abu Dhabi's **Mubadala** operates it and licenses the process, and Washington takes a slice of that operator. GlobalFoundries also moved **$955m** of its CHIPS award into photonics, SiGe and advanced packaging — which is where this story meets the next.[1]

Because a day later **TSMC** conceded a shortage at exactly that point in the chain. Chairman **C.C. Wei** told analysts that **"the CoWoS is still the number one choice for our customer"** — and that TSMC is buying **interposer capacity from GlobalFoundries** to relieve a back-end bottleneck. The foundry that owns the front end is renting the back end from the company Japan just hired.[2]

TSMC'S THIRD QUARTER, AGAINST ITS OWN GUIDANCE

MEASURE	ACTUAL	GUIDED
Revenue	US$46.72bn	44.6–45.8
Gross margin	66.4%	65.0–67.0
Operating margin	58.7%	56.0–58.0
HPC share	68%	—

Revenue rose 50.9% year on year; earnings per share 68.7%. Node mix: 2nm 8%, 3nm 33%, 5nm 28% — 79% at 7nm and below.[2]

$60–64bn

TSMC'S 2026 CAPITAL BUDGET, WHICH CHIEF FINANCIAL OFFICER WENDELL HUANG REITERATED RATHER THAN RAISED — AND DECLINED TO EXTEND TO 2027[2]

ALSO THIS WEEK

Judge Maryellen Noreika has still not ruled on the five-year royalty-suspension clause or on Arm's duty to negotiate in good faith. Closing arguments in the bench phase are set for **Tuesday 20 October**, ninety minutes split evenly. The jury's verdict — a breach found, **$2** awarded — settled the smaller question.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT MANAGEMENT ACTUALLY SAID

Wei on demand: **"the demand is extremely robust... We did not see any sign of slowdown."** On the accelerator growth rate: **"Whether it is a high 50 CAGR, it does not matter. It probably will be higher."** Huang on cost: **"The tool price inflation is real,"** with overseas-fab dilution widening to **3–4%**. Wei's one caution was about buyers, not builders. Nothing in the transcript mentions the Middle East, Hormuz or energy costs.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · A RECORD QUARTER, MARKED DOWN

Taiwan's Taiex fell **3.41%** on the day TSMC reported its sixth straight record quarter, and Korea's Kospi fell **7.57%** into a circuit breaker (p14). If earnings that good are marked down that hard, the market is not disputing the earnings — it is repricing the discount rate. The sovereignty story points the same way: Japan is financing fabs that open in **2029**, at a moment when the cost of capital is moving every screen.[12]

SOURCES 1 GlobalFoundries' own release of 14 October 2026, read at source, for the $21bn and $10bn figures, the quoted sentence that Japan provides the investment, GF's role, the Commerce stake, both executives' quotations, the wafer capacity, the 2029 date and the $955m CHIPS reallocation. **GF's release does not state ownership; joint US–Japan ownership is Reuters' reporting, carried by a trade publication read at source. GF's fees are disclosed nowhere.** 2 TSMC's Form 6-K, read at source on SEC EDGAR, for revenue, margins and node mix; its own investor-relations page for the guidance the actuals are measured against; the 15 October call transcript, read at source, for every quotation, the capital budget, the packaging and interposer remarks. **The transcript gives two different cash figures in one passage, so none is printed.** 3 Qualcomm's own statement, 13 October 2026, read at source. **Arm's own statement could not be read: its newsroom index serves a headline with no body. The claim-by-claim tally is disputed between outlets and is not printed.** The 20 October date is single-sourced court reporting. 4 Reuters, Baptista and Pan, dateline Beijing 13 October, read at source in syndication.

THE HOME LAB · NEMOTRON BOLT

Nemotron Bolt fits 74 billion parameters in 24GB and runs slower

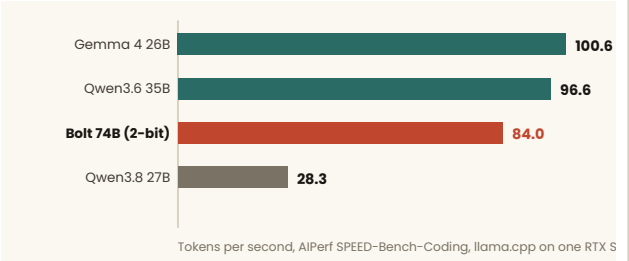
Nemotron 3.5 Bolt quantises expert weights to 2.0625 bits. On NVIDIA's own benchmark it runs at 84 tokens a second, behind a 35B and a 26B.

NVIDIA released **Nemotron 3.5 Bolt 74B-A9B** on **15 October** — 74 billion total parameters, **9 billion active**, distilled from a 120-billion parent and squeezed under 24GB by quantising the routed and shared expert weights to **IQ2_XXS, 2.0625 bits per element**, with Mamba layers at NVFP4 and attention left at Q8_0. Expert top-K was cut from 22 to 9. The compression is genuinely impressive engineering.[1]

The speed is not. NVIDIA's own research page publishes the benchmark, measured with **llama.cpp** on a Microsoft Surface Laptop Ultra: Bolt turns in **83.99 tokens a second** on AIPerf SPEED-Bench-Coding, against **96.63** for Qwen3.6-35B-A3B and **100.56** for Gemma 4 26B-A4B. On agent replay it needs **600.80 seconds** where the Qwen takes **453.97**. NVIDIA's prose claims **"higher accuracy than leading models with similar memory footprints and speed."** Its own table does not support the second half.[1]

On accuracy the claim holds up: Bolt wins **ten of thirteen** published benchmarks against BF16 rivals — Terminal-Bench 2.1 at **50.98** against 44.38, GPQA Diamond **86.43** against 83.40, BrowseComp **66.75** against 48.74. It loses PinchBench, and it loses **both hallucination metrics**: non-hallucination **61.27** against a rival's 68.81. A two-bit model that answers more questions correctly and makes things up more often is an honest trade, and NVIDIA published both halves.[2]

Read the deployment notes before clearing disk space. The GGUF repository asks for an **RTX Spark with 64GB**, or a discrete card with **32GB of VRAM** for the short-context recipe and **48GB** for the long one. "Fits in 24GB" describes the weights, not the working set: a 3090 or a 4090 is not the target.[3]



The two-bit 74B is the red bar. *Meridian* original, plotted from NVIDIA Research's own published table.[1]

2

COMMENTS DRAWN BY NEMOTRON BOLT ACROSS FIVE SEPARATE HACKER NEWS SUBMISSIONS IN ITS FIRST 24 HOURS[4]

THE CHATTER · AN INDEPENDENT NUMBER, AND A SHRUG

StorageReview benchmarked the **same machine on the same day** and measured Qwen3.6-35B-A3B at **89.2 tokens a second** against NVIDIA's **96.63** — two labs, one laptop, about **8%** apart, close enough that the frame holds. The community read is stranger. Across its first day Bolt drew **five** Hacker News submissions totalling **two comments**. A seventy-four-billion-parameter model that fits on a laptop landed with two comments. Either the home-lab crowd lacks hardware clearing the 32GB floor, or it read the speed table.[4][5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT WAS NOT PUBLISHED

NVIDIA published no time-to-first-token, **no perplexity** and no accuracy retention against the BF16 original — the three numbers that would say what two-bit quantisation cost. The speculative decoder is credited with raising acceptance to **4.68** tokens greedily, but its speed-up over the previous drafter is **not quantified**. Unsloth's comparison table is headed **ONGOING** and is empty. The compression is real and measurable. Everything that would let you price it is missing, and the only tokens-per-second figure for this model in existence is the vendor's.[1][3]

SOURCES 1 NVIDIA Research's own Nemotron 3.5 Bolt technical page, read at source, for the parameter counts, the distillation parent, the IQ2_XXS quantisation at 2.0625 bits per element, the NVFP4 and Q8_0 assignments, the expert top-K reduction, the quoted claim, and every figure in the benchmark table and the chart above. The benchmark is NVIDIA's own, run with llama.cpp on Windows on Arm on a single Surface Laptop Ultra. 2 NVIDIA's Hugging Face model card for the 24GB build, read at source, for the full accuracy table including both hallucination metrics; the comparison is NVIDIA's selection of rivals at BF16. **NVIDIA notes that its own run of one rival on the 500 public MCP-Atlas tasks scored lower than that rival reports.** 3 NVIDIA's GGUF repository, read at source, for both deployment recipes and the VRAM floors; Unsloth's GGUF repository and run guide, read at source, for the 22GB file size and the RAM guidance. **The two sources disagree on maximum context and the disagreement is printed rather than resolved. Unsloth publishes no tokens-per-second and no perplexity, and its KLD section is marked ONGOING and empty.** 4 Hacker News, queried through its public search API and read at source, for all five submissions with their points, comment counts and timestamps. 5 StorageReview's review of the same laptop, Kevin OBrien, 15 October 2026, read at source, for the independently measured 89.2 tokens a second. **Quantisation is not stated for that run, which is a real limit on the comparison. Reddit was unreachable by every route tried, so no r/LocalLLaMA sentiment is sourced anywhere in this issue.** 6 NVIDIA's own blog post of 13 October, read at source.

THE KIT · SURFACE LAPTOP ULTRA

Microsoft ships the Surface Laptop Ultra, unlisted on its Singapore site

The first NVIDIA RTX Spark laptop starts at US$2,599.99. Apple opens iPhone Duo pre-orders here at 8pm tonight, from S$3,099.

Microsoft begins shipping the **Surface Laptop Ultra** today, **16 October**, at **US$2,599.99** — the first Surface built on NVIDIA's Arm-based **RTX Spark** platform. Microsoft's own page specifies a **15-inch** 120Hz touchscreen at **2,000 nits** peak, up to **128GB** of unified memory, under **4.5 lb** and under 18mm, with a Grace CPU of up to twenty cores. It publishes one price, no ship date and no market list; the ladder to **US$5,899.99** comes from reviewers with store access, not from Microsoft.[1]

As of this morning, **Microsoft's Singapore Surface site lists neither the Laptop Ultra nor the RTX Spark Dev Box** — it offers a Surface Pro from **S$1,559** and a Surface Laptop with no price at all. The Singapore URL for the machine resolves to the American page in US dollars; the trade-in promotion runs in the United States and Canada only; and NVIDIA's six launch events — Taipei, Seoul, Beijing, Istanbul, San Francisco, Berlin — include **no Southeast Asian market**.[2]

That is the third week running this desk has found a Singapore-shaped hole, after Ray-Ban Meta Audio (No. 133) and nine Apple accessories excluded from the local newsroom (No. 132). It is now a pattern rather than an incident — and the counter-example arrives the same day. **Apple opens iPhone Duo pre-orders in Singapore at 8pm tonight**, on sale **23 October**, at **S$3,099** for 256GB rising to **S$4,899** for two terabytes, GST included. Singapore is in the first wave.[3]

What the Surface buys is bandwidth. StorageReview measured **STREAM Copy at 130,516 MB/s**, about **2.6×** the AMD machines it tested against, and ran Qwen3.6-35B-A3B at **89.2 tokens a second**. The cost is latency: **251.1 nanoseconds** to memory against a rival's 115.5, and core-to-core **171.6** against 49.7. Huge bandwidth, poor latency — the honest shape of this chip.[4]

3 in 4

ATTEMPTS IN WHICH A US$5,899.99 SURFACE LAPTOP ULTRA CUT ITS OWN POWER ON 14 OCTOBER, 14 TO 16 SECONDS INTO AN ALL-CORE SOLVE, WITH NO THERMAL SHUTDOWN LOGGED[4]

IN BRIEF

Xreal put the One Pro+ on sale at US$600, the same price as the One Pro, with peak brightness raised to **1,200 nits** from 700 and 2D-to-3D conversion doubled to 60Hz. Resolution, weight and markets unstated.[5]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND

Engadget's **Devindra Hardawar** relays NVIDIA's claim that RTX Spark is **twice as efficient** as an Intel Core Ultra 9 285H with an RTX 5070 at 60W — but notes he recorded no frame rates himself, that gaming on Arm rests on **Prism emulation** with anti-cheat **"promised but not yet proven,"** and that he would still choose an x86 machine with a discrete card for games. One oddity from the lab: SuperTuxKart ran at **235.9 fps** native and **264.6** under x86 emulation. The emulated build beat the native one.[46]

THE SCEPTIC · IT TURNED ITSELF OFF

On the evening of **14 October**, StorageReview's review unit powered off **three times in four attempts** running an OpenBLAS solve on twenty threads — each time **14 to 16 seconds** in. Every restart logged **Kernel-Power 41, bugcheck code 0**: no crash dump, no fatal hardware error, **no thermal shutdown event**. Heat is ruled out: the same machine had held **98°C for 31 minutes** without faulting. A first unit had already been replaced after dying the same way. The verdict is measured: **"a workstation-class laptop should survive its heaviest legitimate workload, and until Microsoft or NVIDIA explains what tripped, that is the open question on this machine."**[47]

SOURCES 1 Microsoft's own product page, read at source, for the price, the 15-inch 120Hz display, the 2,000-nit peak, the memory and storage ceilings, the weight and the Grace core count. **Microsoft publishes no ladder, ship date, battery figure or market list; the $5,899.99 top is given by two reviewers with store access. Engadget says 16-inch; Microsoft's own page says 15, and Microsoft's figure is used.** 2 Microsoft's Singapore Surface site, read at source this morning; NVIDIA's own RTX Spark page for the launch cities. **The Singapore storefront returned 503, so this reports the marketing site only, and states an absence as at 16 October — not that the device will not be sold here.** 3 Apple's own Singapore store pages for all four prices and both dates; a Singapore consumer site as second source. **Apple's SG newsroom serves no listings, so prices are read from the store.** 4 StorageReview, Kevin OBrien, 15 October 2026, read at source, for every measured figure, the power-loss sequence, the event codes and the quoted verdict. **Quantisation is not stated for any model benchmarked.** 5 Engadget, three reports of 14–15 October, each read at source, each single-sourced. 6 Engadget, Devindra Hardawar, 15 October. **His performance figures are NVIDIA-supplied or observational; he says so.** 7 A German laboratory's prototype report of 29 July 2026 — outside the window, included only because it predicted the fault class.

THE GOOD LIFE · MING 57.09

MING and Massena LAB sold out 125 watches on Wednesday morning

The 57.09 "Secret Honey" went on sale at 9am New York time at CHF 7,250. Its maker's page now says sold out and also quotes eight to twelve weeks.

MING, of Kuala Lumpur, and **Massena LAB** put the **57.09 "Secret Honey"** on sale at **9am New York time on Wednesday 15 October**, in an edition of **125 pieces** that MING's own page says **"will not be produced again."** The price reported is **CHF 7,250**, about **US$8,650**. MING's page carries no price at all — only the words "excluding taxes" — so the franc figure is the press's, not the maker's.[1]

The mechanism is the point. A dark brown lacquered base dial sits under **three rotating sapphire discs** turning on **24-hour, 12-hour and 60-minute** cycles, so the amber pattern reorganises itself continuously — MING calls it **"dynamic guilloche,"** which is an honest description of a thing no engine-turning lathe can do. The case is grade 5 titanium, **40mm by 10.17**, 47.8 lug to lug, with stepped lugs in three tones: bare titanium, TiN and TiSiN. Inside is a Sellita-for-MING **330.M2**, 25 jewels, four hertz, about fifty hours.[1]

Sold out is where the reporting should stop, because the maker's own page contradicts itself: it says sold out and **"deliveries complete,"** offers a waitlist, and simultaneously lists a delivery time of **eight to twelve weeks**. This desk therefore prints that MING's page lists the watch as sold out, notes the contradiction, and declines to report a sell-out time — a number the watch internet will circulate by tonight regardless.[1]

There is history worth knowing. The **2021 predecessor**, the 17.09, sold through so fast that it **"angered many Instagram commenters,"** and owners afterwards reported quality and mechanical problems the two brands resolved. Surviving examples still trade well above retail. That is why the sequel is read as growth rather than scarcity marketing: MING has since adjusted production numbers and staggered its releases.[2]

ALSO ON SALE THIS WEEK

Jack Mason's Strat-o-timer 42 "Dr Pepper" — 230 numbered pieces at **US$1,299**, no on-sale date published.[3]

Bamford London and AETHER's D-300 — 50 numbered pieces at **US$2,950**, black ceramic over a titanium core, 42mm, 300m, Sellita SW200.[3]

Timex and Noah's Boatswain — **US$228** from 11am on 15 October, and not a limited edition, which on this page counts as news.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHERE MING ACTUALLY TRADES

This desk reached no live forum on this watch: **Reddit blocked at both domains, Watchuseek behind a paywall, Hodinkee blocked outright**. No sentiment on the Secret Honey is printed, because none was obtained. What can be evidenced is the market's shape, from a watch-market data site read at source: over twelve months **Reddit is MING's largest secondary marketplace — 131 listings, 67 sales** — against Watchuseek's **24 listings and no recorded sales at all**. Those are older references. It is still striking: the resale market for a Malaysian atelier's work lives on a message board, and the watch forum proper has become a window display.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · PRAISE CONDITIONAL ON A FIX

The only genuinely critical voice this desk found — Worn & Wound's **Zach Kazan** — is critical of the lineage rather than the object, and that is the sharper cut. His approval of the sequel rests entirely on MING having repaired a problem it created: the 2021 drop angered buyers, **"widely reported QC and mechanical issues followed,"** and the brand has since changed how it releases watches. Praise contingent on remediation is not the same as praise. Note also what the rest of the coverage is: Gear Patrol's piece carries an **affiliate-commission disclosure** and contains no criticism whatever, and the week's other two write-ups are equally promotional. On the adjacent release, aBlogtoWatch's **Ripley Sellers** does concede that the standard AETHER D-300 sits **"in the low four figures,"** which prices the collaboration's premium at roughly double — for a colourway.[23]

SOURCES 1 MING's own product page, read at source, for the edition size, the "will not be produced again" statement, the sold-out status, the waitlist, the eight-to-twelve-week line, and every specification. **MING's page shows no price; the franc figure and its dollar equivalent come from two watch publications and are attributed to them. The sold-out and eight-to-twelve-week statements sit on the same page and are irreconcilable, which is why no sell-out time is printed.** 2 Worn & Wound, Zach Kazan, 14 October 2026, read at source, for the on-sale time, the 2021 predecessor's reception, the quoted phrases, the subsequent quality reports and his argument about the brand's changed practice. 3 aBlogtoWatch, 14 and 15 October, and Gear Patrol, 14 October, each read at source. **Gear Patrol's piece carries an affiliate-commission disclosure; the Jack Mason write-up is promotional and contains no criticism.** 4 A watch-market data site, read at source, for the listing and sales counts.

SCREEN & SOUND · DOPAMINE CHAMBER

NME reviewed Fontaines D.C.'s Dopamine Chamber four days before release

The five-star NME verdict was filed four days before release, and a Metacritic score of 84 was circulating by Thursday.

Fontaines D.C. released their fifth album, **Dopamine Chamber**, on **XL Recordings** today, **Friday 16 October**. It is produced by **James Ford**, and **Rosalía** appears on **"Where Is Gone?"** — the first outside artist ever to feature on a Fontaines song. **NME**'s five-star review, by **Andrew Trendell**, was published on **Monday 12 October**: four days before anyone outside the process could hear it.[1]

Trendell's verdict is unambiguous. **"Comfort is rigor mortis for Fontaines,"** he writes, and **"The biggest Irish band since U2 have now also secured themselves as the definitive band of this decade."** By Tuesday the Irish press was aggregating the aggregation: **The Journal** reported five stars from NME, **9 out of 10** from Hot Press — **"the defining act of the Nervous '20s"** — and The Guardian calling it **"their most formidable and cohesive record"** by **"the best band of their generation."**[2]

A Metascore of **84** on **14 reviews** was being quoted on Thursday, the day before release. This desk cannot stand behind it: **Metacritic refused both the album page and the critic listing**, so the figure reaches us at one remove and is printed as unverified. What is verifiable is the shape: a consensus assembled, scored and published before the public had access to the work being scored.[3]

No. 133 noted the Official Charts Company forecasting a number one four days ahead of its own data. This is the same clock run on criticism rather than sales, and the two complaints differ. A pre-release embargo is ordinary and useful. What is new is the **aggregate** — a number that exists to summarise a settled critical reception, computed while the reception has not yet happened.[3]

4 days

BETWEEN NME'S FIVE-STAR REVIEW OF DOPAMINE CHAMBER AND THE ALBUM'S RELEASE[1]

ALSO OUT

Drake's HABIBTI climbed from 116 to No. 2 on the Billboard 200 dated 17 October, in its **21st week**; Taylor Swift holds the top in a **53rd**. Billboard's explanatory article is paywalled, so there are no unit figures and no account of the 114-place jump.[4]

Opening today in the United States: a *Sense and Sensibility*, *Whalefall*, *Street Fighter*, and *You Can See Everything* by Nathan Fielder and Lance Oppenheim, which The Film Stage made its pick of the month.[5]

THE CHATTER · THE ONLY AUDIENCE THIS DESK COULD REACH

Reddit was unreachable at both domains, and no thread on this record surfaced by any other route, so there is no fan read here worth the name. The single attributable audience voice comes from an unlikely place: the comment thread beneath **The Journal**'s own round-up of the five-star reviews, where the paper reports some of its readers worrying that **the weight of the hype could damage the band**. That is readers of an Irish news site, not a music community, and it is labelled as exactly that. It is also, for what it is worth, the only dissenting note anyone put in writing before the record came out — and it was about the reviews rather than the music.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · FOURTEEN IS NOT A CONSENSUS

The reported outlier is **Slant Magazine at 50**, whose objection reaches this desk only through the page that refused it, as does **Pitchfork's 78**. Both are marked second-hand and neither is quoted. The structural point survives the sourcing problem: an **84** built on fourteen reviews with no negatives is not a measurement of how an album was received. It is a measurement of which fourteen publications were given it early. The test will come in a fortnight, when outlets that bought the record rather than being sent it have filed — and nobody will update the headline figure.[3]

SOURCES 1 NME's own review, Andrew Trendell, published 12 October 2026, read at source, for both quoted sentences, the release date and the label. **The star rating is not rendered in the page text this desk received; five stars is confirmed by the second source.** 2 The Journal (Ireland), 13 October 2026, read at source, for the NME confirmation, the Hot Press score and quotation, both Guardian quotations, the Rosalía feature, the producer, and the paper's own summary of its readers' comments. 3 The aggregate score, review count, split and per-outlet figures including Slant and Pitchfork: **Metacritic returned HTTP 403 on both the album page and the critic listing, so none of this was read at source. It is reported at one remove, marked unverified, and no reviewer is quoted from it.** 4 The Billboard 200 dated 17 October 2026, read at source on the publisher's Canadian edition. **Its explanatory article returned payment-required, so there are no unit figures. The same page shows one entry as new while giving it 71 weeks on chart; that entry is not reported.** 5 Release listings read through the search layer only; the albums page returned 429 to a direct fetch. **Only the Fontaines release is printed as established fact.**

THE FAMILY DESK · ADOLESCENT ANXIETY

JAMA Pediatrics reports one in six US adolescents screening positive

The JAMA Pediatrics study surveyed 15,730 twelve- to twenty-year-olds. Four in ten of the worst affected received no treatment in a year.

Tanner Bommersbach and colleagues reported in **JAMA Pediatrics** on **12 October** that **16.8%** of US adolescents — **2,851 of 15,730** — screened positive for moderate or severe anxiety. The band matters here more than usual: the sample runs **12 to 20**, which places a twelve-year-old at the very floor of it. The data come from the **2024 National Survey on Drug Use and Health**, in the first year it carried anxiety items at all.[1]

The gradients are steep. Moderate symptoms reached **13.4%** of girls against **6.0%** of boys; severe, **10.8%** against **3.7%** — girls roughly **2.9 times** as likely to screen severe. Among those scoring severe, **65.8%** had a past-year major depressive episode and **48.2%** reported past-year suicidal thoughts. And **41.2%** of the severe group, with **48.3%** of the moderate, had received no mental-health treatment of any kind in the preceding year.[1]

Two cautions belong in the same breath as the number. The instrument is the **GAD-7**, a seven-item self-report screener derived in adults, and its right cut-off in adolescents is contested: a Hong Kong community study of 15- to 24-year-olds found the best threshold at **7** and warned that a score of seven **"should not be used as a formal diagnostic screening tool."** So 16.8% is the share who screened positive, not the share with a disorder.[2]

The second is simpler and more often ignored. The study is **cross-sectional and single-year**, and 2024 was the first year these items existed in the survey — so there is **no trend in this paper at all**. Anyone citing it to show that adolescent anxiety is rising is citing something it does not contain.[1]

41.2%

OF ADOLESCENTS SCREENING SEVERE WHO HAD RECEIVED NO MENTAL-HEALTH TREATMENT IN THE PREVIOUS YEAR; 48.3% OF THE MODERATE GROUP[1]

THE CHATTER · THE REPORTABLE SILENCE

This desk went looking for what Singapore parents were discussing this week and found an absence worth printing. On the island's largest parenting site, during a week when the air-quality index passed **200** and the Education Minister was publicly discussing closing schools, there was **not one item about haze and children**. What was published on 13 and 15 October: secondary-school open houses, whether to monitor a teenager's grades for junior-college admission, critical thinking in preschoolers, and two free workshops — one on artificial intelligence and your child, one on cyber-wellness. The published anxiety is about admissions and screens. **The site's forum refused this desk and Reddit refused every route**, so there is no thread-level sentiment here and none is invented.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · PREVALENCE INFLATION, STATED AS ITS AUTHOR DOES

Lucy Foulkes of Oxford and **Jack Andrews** proposed in 2023 the **prevalence inflation hypothesis**: that awareness campaigns have two effects, one benign — people recognising symptoms they could not previously name — and one not, a drift towards reinterpreting ordinary distress as disorder, with the label feeding back into how a young person understands and behaves. It is the most serious objection to a headline like this one. It is also, on **Foulkes's own research page, explicitly not yet tested**: her group and others are still collecting data, and no published test is listed. This desk prints it as she presents it — an open question with real force, not a refutation. The honest position is that both can be true: that too many twelve-year-olds are frightened, and that a seven-question form is a poor instrument for finding out which.[4]

General guidance, not medical advice. A screener is a prompt to ask a question, not a diagnosis, and the paper's own authors do not treat it as one.

SOURCES 1 Bommersbach TJ, Fontanella CA, Olfson M, Rhee TG, "Estimates of Anxiety Symptoms Among US Adolescents," *JAMA Pediatrics*, published online 12 October 2026, read at source: the sample and sex split, the 12–20 band, the survey and its first inclusion of anxiety items, the GAD-7, every share and count, the sex gradients, the comorbidity figures and both untreated proportions. **The paper reports no confidence intervals and no odds ratios for the treatment disparities, which are qualitative; none is printed. Secondary coverage credited a co-author as its author — the first author is Bommersbach.** 2 A Hong Kong validation study of 15- to 24-year-olds in *BMC Psychiatry* (2022) for the threshold and quoted warning; a South African validation for the sensitivity at a cut-off of 6; a published commentary and the authors' reply for the dispute over inflated counts at low cut points. All read at source. 3 A Singapore parenting site's own article list, read at source with dates, and its events listing. **The finding is an absence across that list, not a claim about the site's forum, which returned 403. Reddit was unreachable by every route.** 4 Foulkes L and Andrews JL, *New Ideas in Psychology* (2023), as described on Foulkes's own research page, read at source — including her statement that the hypothesis remains untested.

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE NUMBER 300

Desmond Lee drew the school-closure line at PSI 300

The central index stood at 168 when he wrote that on 10 October; by Friday morning NEA's own feed read 219. Examinations continue in air-purified halls.

Education Minister **Desmond Lee** wrote on **10 October** that the Ministry of Education would consider closing schools and postponing national examinations only if the **next day's 24-hour PSI forecast exceeded 300** — the top, hazardous band. Any closure would be announced at about **8pm the evening before**. Until then, lessons and examinations continue in enclosed venues with air purifiers, and every classroom is to have one, though no count is given.[1]

When he wrote it, the central 24-hour index stood at **168**. At **5am on Friday 16 October** it read **219** (p5). Between those two numbers sits the band in which a twelve-year-old is now sitting papers: in the **unhealthy range of 101 to 200**, no strenuous outdoor activity is permitted, and any student who is unwell or has a pre-existing lung or heart condition is exempt from **all** outdoor physical activity. A child too unwell to sit a paper may apply for Special Consideration through the school.[1]

The machinery behind the decision is larger than the Ministry: the Haze Task Force is led by the National Environment Agency and draws in **28 government agencies**. Lee's own undertaking was that **"we will continue to monitor the situation closely each day,"** and that **"the health and well-being of our students and staff remain our top priority."** The 200 warning the agency issued alongside it has now landed. The 300 has not.[1]

For a parent the practical question is narrower than the policy one, and it is about what a threshold is for. A published line lets a family plan: it says in advance what will happen and when, so nobody has to read a minister's mood on a Tuesday afternoon. Its cost is that it must be set somewhere defensible, and 300 is a long way above the band the island has actually been breathing for the past eleven days.[2]

THE CHATTER · THE FORUM GOT THERE FIRST

Singapore's largest technology forum spent Thursday night on precisely this arithmetic, and its objection is sharper than most published commentary. **compro_1975**, on the closure threshold: **"talk so big, but 280 cant even forecast.... 300 then how?"** The point is technical and fair — the policy is keyed to a **forecast** of next-day 24-hour PSI, and the week's highest hourly reading reached **288** without any 24-hour forecast approaching it. **Hypernova** read the undertaking more cynically: he **"will think about it and probably wait for it to drop." coolmyth** predicted closure would be timed to the school holidays. None of this is a reason to close schools. All of it is a reason to explain the number better than it has been explained.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T CATASTROPHISE THE EXAM HALL

The case against alarm is decent and should be made. An air-purified indoor hall is among the better places in Singapore to spend a hazy morning; the alternative for most families is a flat with windows that open onto the same air and, often, no purifier at all. Closing schools sends children home, not into clean air, and takes a working parent out of an office that is filtered. The 2015 episode, which was worse and longer, produced no measurable national examination effect that this desk could find published. What the evidence supports is narrower and duller than either panic or reassurance: keep the exempt list honest, keep the purifiers running and serviced, and tell parents what the forecast actually is — because the thing that frightens a twelve-year-old is not a number, it is watching the adults improvise.[2]

WHAT A PARENT CAN ACT ON

The exemption is a right, not a favour. Unwell, or asthmatic — no outdoor physical activity at all in the unhealthy band, and schools are instructed to apply it.[1]

General guidance, not medical advice. A child with a diagnosed respiratory condition should be managed on their doctor's plan, not on a public threshold.

SOURCES 1 The Education Minister's public post of 10 October 2026, as reported by a Singapore news site the same evening and read at source, for the 300 forecast threshold, the 8pm announcement practice, the continuation of lessons and examinations in air-purified venues, both quotations, the Special Consideration route, the unhealthy-band restrictions and the exemption for unwell students, and the composition of the Haze Task Force. **The Ministry's own release page returned empty to this desk and a regional outlet refused it, so no ministry-issued document was obtained; this is the minister's post as reported.** 2 The index readings are sourced on p5 from the National Environment Agency's own real-time feed, queried directly at 05:00 on 16 October 2026; the 10 October comparison is from the same reporting as note 1. **That the 2015 episode produced no published national-examination effect is the result of a search that found none, not a finding that none occurred.** 3 A Singapore technology forum thread of 15 October 2026, read at source, usernames as posted. The 288 figure is the year's highest hourly reading, recorded in the west on 14 October and sourced on p5. **Reddit was unreachable by every route tried, so no parenting-subreddit sentiment appears in this issue.**

THE MACRO DESK · THE KOSPI CIRCUIT BREAKER

Korea's Kospi fell 7.57% into a circuit breaker

Samsung lost 9.5% and SK hynix 11.1% on 15 October. Hours later the US ten-year fell 11 basis points and the S&P closed up 0.26%.

The **Kospi** closed at **5,554.22** on Thursday **15 October**, down **7.57%**, after a circuit breaker halted trading for **twenty minutes**. **Samsung Electronics** fell **9.5%**, **SK hynix 11.1%**, and foreigners sold a net **3.6 trillion won**. Japan's Nikkei fell **4.90%** in a sixth straight session of losses, and Taiwan's Taiex **3.41%** — on the day TSMC posted a record quarter (p7).[1]

The cause is upstream and it is the war. September US consumer prices rose **3.7%** against 3.6% expected, with **gasoline up 34.2%** year on year and **fuel oil 74.2%**. White House adviser **Kevin Hassett** conceded it plainly: **"the energy shock is really the headline story today."** Pump gasoline is **$4.33** a gallon against **$2.98** before the war. The impulse shows up abroad too — China's producer prices at **5.0%**, India's wholesale index at **11.39%**.[2]

Wednesday took the hit at the long end: the ten-year reached **5.30%** intraday and the thirty-year **5.625%**, the Philadelphia semiconductor index fell **4.5%** and gold dropped as much as **2.1%**. Thursday the bond market blinked. The curve **bull-flattened** — ten-year down **11.2** basis points, thirty-year **11.6** — and the odds of a Federal Reserve hike this month fell to **25%** from **37%**. The S&P closed **up 0.26%** while Asia was still bleeding.[3]

Name the regime: **higher-for-longer cracking into a liquidity-tight de-rating**, with a dollar that has stopped working as the haven. The tell is TSMC. A record quarter, margins above its own guidance, a chief executive saying he sees **"no sign of slowdown"** — and the index it sits in fell **3.41%**. When earnings that good are marked down that hard, the market is not disputing the earnings. It is repricing what a future dollar of them is worth.[4]

THE LEVELS · AT THURSDAY'S CLOSE

VWRA	$191.48	▼ 0.16%
Global agg (AGGU)	$5.77	▲ 0.52%
US 10-year	5.074%	▼ 11bp
DXY	101.98	▼ 0.56%
Brent	$105.73	▼ 0.31%
Gold, spot	$4,170.81	▲ 1.59%
Bitcoin	$82,077	▲ 0.50%

Arrows follow each number's own sign. Brent trades across contract months at different snapshot times; the honest band on Thursday was **$104–106**. Not advice.[5]

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

VWRA is flat on the week and **+17.34%** over a year: the de-rating is concentrated in the long-duration, semiconductor-heavy end, and an all-world index is doing what it exists to do. **Global bonds** finally helped — AGGU rose **0.52%** on a day equities broke. Hold that lightly: its one-year total return is still **−0.41%**. Bonds hedged Thursday; they have not hedged the year. **Gold** rose **1.59%** as yields and the dollar fell, but with inflation at 3.7% and the ten-year at 5.07% a real yield near **1.4%** is still a headwind — which is why gold is **−2.18%** on the month despite a war at the world's most important oil chokepoint. **Bitcoin** did almost nothing, and that is the tell: it prices liquidity and risk appetite, not scarcity. Explanation, not advice.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · ONE DAY IS NOT A CORRELATION

The cheerful reading of Thursday — bonds rallying as equities wobbled, diversification restored — rests on one session. The Fed-hike odds that fell to 25% were **37%** the day before: a market changing its mind twice in forty-eight hours rather than forming a view. The Singapore leg carries the same warning. The **Straits Times Index fell only 0.37%** on a day Korea fell 7.57%, which looks like resilience and may only be composition. **MAS held policy on 14 October** against a poll expecting tightening, while saying **"the risks to inflation remain tilted to the upside."** A central bank that holds while saying that is not relaxed.[6]

SOURCES 1 An Asia market wrap of 15 October 2026, read at source, for every regional index close, the circuit-breaker halt, both Korean falls, the net foreign selling and the quoted undertaking; the previous day's wrap supplies the closes against which each move reconciles exactly. 2 The September US CPI release as reported in a bank's Asia-Pacific note, read at source, for the headline, expected and energy components; a US broadcaster's live file for both pump prices; the same wraps for China's PPI and India's WPI. 3 The same note for Wednesday's intraday peaks, the semiconductor index, the gold fall and the dollar; a market-data service for Thursday's settlement yields and changes; the Asia wrap for the shift in hike odds. 4 Sourced on p7. 5 Levels read at source on 15 October: VWRA and the bond proxy from a listed-fund service; yields, the dollar, both crosses, Brent and gold from a market-data service; bitcoin from a cryptoasset service. **Brent and WTI differ by contract month and snapshot across sources, so a band is printed. A broadcaster carrying slightly different figures refused this desk. The Friday Asia session had not closed when this page was set; no Friday level appears on it.** 6 The Monetary Authority's own statement of 14 October, read at source, for the hold and the quoted risk; the Oxford Economics view and the STI close from the wraps above. **That a Reuters poll expected tightening reaches this desk through a single blog and is reported as that.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · CAVING & SPELEOLOGY

Volunteers gave Britain 5,570 unpaid hours of cave rescue in 2025

Sport caving has 8,500 members in America and 154 clubs in Britain. Its characteristic emergency is not a fall but a cold, lost party.

Sport caving is the exploration of **wild** caves — unlit, unpaved, unguided — using rope, light and your own body. It is not the show cave, with its handrails and electric lighting and guide. It is not cave diving either, which the literature treats as a separate and more hazardous speciality; Britain's rescue statistics record **zero** cave-diving incidents in each of the last five years, which tells you how few and how carefully selected those people are. What is left is darkness, water, mud, squeezes, and pitches: vertical drops you cannot climb, so you rig them with rope.[1]

The vertical discipline is **SRT** — single rope technique — descending and ascending one rope on mechanical devices. That is the skill the gear exists to serve, and it is the reason the hobby has a certification culture at all. Nobody falls into caving by buying something. Three documented routes in: a university club, a regional taster day, or simply asking a local club. On the British forum the advice to beginners is unanimous and specific. **Samouse1**: **"Worth contacting the local caving clubs to see if they can take you under their wing." Lankyman**: **"I joined a club aged sixteen and it was one of the best things I ever did."**[2]

Demand outstrips the door. The Council of Northern Caving Clubs runs the training programme for northern England and Scotland, and of its **fifteen workshops** listed for October to December **eleven are marked full**, the rest with one to four places left — while the council warns it may not be able to keep offering training after December. The scale elsewhere: the National Speleological Society counts **8,500-plus members** and **250 grottos** in America; the British Caving Association lists **154 member clubs**; the forum that functions as the hobby's capital carries **426,006 messages** from **7,173 members**.[3]

And the economics are strange in a way that explains the culture. A British caving membership costs **£32** a year and carries **£20 million** of public liability indemnity — a policy that exists chiefly to reassure the farmer whose field the cave runs under. Caving's core financial instrument is a landowner-relations product.[4]

"Fear doesn't respond well to statistics."

Which brings us to what the next two pages descend into: a community that argues in public about access and ethics; a gear market where one object costs more than everything else combined; a survey-instrument scene currently being rebuilt by two men in sheds; and a safety record that is far better than outsiders assume and far more demanding than they imagine.[5]

THE CHATTER · WHO DOES THIS, IN THEIR OWN WORDS

menacer, on the appeal: **"I think caving just has all the most common phobias in one sport."** Of a club member who disliked both the dark and heights and kept going: **"caving is the only thing I'm good at." wellyjen**: **"Type two fun, but fun none the less."** The warmest thread this desk read all week was started by a man worried he was too large for it. **Steve Clark**: **"Being a larger person is just another factor and it's not a show stopper at all for most caving"** — and, with disarming honesty, **"I was put off caving for many years because it seemed stupid to start something I assumed I had a natural handicap for." caving_fox** supplies the physics: **"To some degree fat and muscle squeezes. Bone really doesn't bend at all." MJenkinson**: **"in most cases it is fitness rather than size that is the limiting factor."**[5]

43 v 12

BRITISH CAVE RESCUES CAUSED BY CAVERS BEING LOST OR OVERDUE, 2021–2025, AGAINST THOSE CAUSED BY A FALL[6]

SOURCES 1 The standard reference description of caving, read at source, for the wild-versus-show distinction and the treatment of cave diving as a separate speciality; the British Cave Rescue Council's 2025 Incident Report (PDF), read at source in full, for the five-year cause table in which cave diving records zero. 2 Two threads on the British caving forum, read at source, dated August 2026 and March 2023, usernames as posted. 3 The northern regional council's own training page, read at source, for the workshop count, the eleven marked full and the warning about future provision; the National Speleological Society's own homepage for its membership and grotto counts; the British Caving Association's own club list, counted by this desk; the forum's own board statistics. **The society's page gives both "8,500+" and "over 8,000" in different places; the figure printed is the one it leads with. No membership figure for the hobby's main subreddit appears anywhere in this desk, because Reddit refused every route tried.** 4 The British Caving Association's own membership and insurance pages, read at source, for all three subscription rates and the indemnity limit. 5 Two further forum threads, September 2022 and October 2025, read at source, usernames and dates as posted. 6 The 2025 Incident Report (PDF) as above, Tables 1 and 2, five-year totals.

THE DEEP END · THE LAMP ON YOUR HEAD

A Scurion 1500 lamp costs £726, more than the rest combined

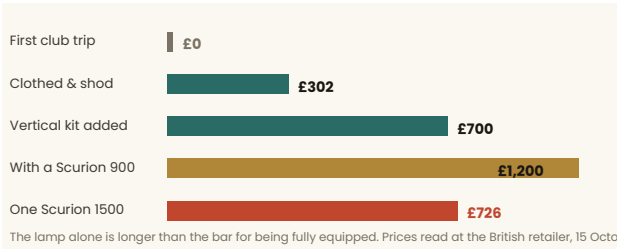
Its maker rates it at 1,300 lumens and its British dealer at 1,600. At full output it runs three hours; at the setting people use, twenty-four.

Everything else a caver wears is modest. A complete, serious beginner's outfit — Cordura oversuit and undersuit at **£174** as a pack, wellies at **£42**, a Petzl helmet at **£52.20**, gloves at **£6.60**, a backup light at **£27** — comes to about **£302**. The vertical kit, bought once and rarely replaced, is **£294 to £399**. Then there is the lamp. A **Scurion 1500**, made in Burgdorf, Switzerland, is **£726** at its British dealer: more than the clothing, the helmet, the boots and the rope work combined.[1]

What it buys is contested in public, and the first contest is the number itself. Scurion's own site rates the 1500 at **1,300 lumens**. Its British dealer lists the same lamp at **1,600**. Neither is lying: the reviewer **Derek Bristol** explains the mechanism exactly — **"Scurion now uses ANSI in its marketing literature, which is a more honest but lower number, but virtually every other manufacturer uses emitter lumens."** One measures light leaving the lamp; the other measures light leaving the diode. Three hundred lumens separate a product from itself.[2]

The second contest is whether the top model is the right one, and the retailer selling it supplies the evidence against. The 1500 at maximum **"will last nearly 3 hours"**; dropped two levels it gives **"around 24 hours."** Eight times the runtime for a quarter of the brightness — so the entire premium over the **900** at **£609** buys a setting you cannot afford to use on a long trip. The insider's call is the 900.[3]

The vertical hardware, by contrast, has barely moved in twenty years, and the prices are almost domestic. A Petzl **Super Avanti** harness is **£70.50** in Yorkshire — and **$159.95** in Tennessee, a transatlantic spread worth noticing. A chest harness is **£19.80**. The **5mm delta maillon** that holds the whole system to the harness is **£2.40**. A spare descender bobbin is **£10.80**. The most important object in the kit costs less than lunch.[1]



The ladder, and the object that breaks it. *Meridian* original, plotted from retailer prices read at source.[1]

THE CHATTER · THE COMMUNITY MAP, AND ITS ARGUMENTS

The forum is the capital — **34,280 threads**, **426,006 messages** — and its access-politics board runs at about **83 messages a thread**, which is where the heat is. The standing arguments are conservation against exploration, bolting ethics, and whether cave locations should be published at all. Around it: the American society's **250 grottos**, the regional councils that run the permits, and a For Sale and Wanted board of **1,900 threads** that tells you more about the culture than any manifesto. At Gaping Gill, Britain's most famous shaft, two clubs winch members of the public down it annually, **for nothing**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE TREADMILL THAT ISN'T

Most gear hobbies run on replacement. This one runs on repair, and the evidence is hard. **Scurion's own standing offer**: **"You can have your Scurion lamp be upgraded or modified any time when a new, more efficient LED shows up!"** — the grail is explicitly designed not to be superseded. The retailer specifies a suit's velcro closure **"for easy user repl[acement]"** and sells patching material at **£24**. The forum's hardware threads are repair threads: boot repair, making your own wetsuit, twenty-two replies on building a battery case from plumbing pipe by people who just spent £105 on a headtorch. The regrets are narrow: **pwhole** was **"shocked, for the price"** at the grail's internals; **Leclused**, an owner, is unsure he would buy again. The money pit in caving is one object, and everyone can name it.[5]

SOURCES 1 A British caving retailer's live catalogue, read at source through its own store interface on 15 October 2026, for every sterling price on this page: the starter pack, wellingtons, helmet, gloves, backup light, SRT kit range, the Scurion 1500 and 900, the Super Avanti, the chest harness, the delta maillon and the spare bobbin; a US retailer's live catalogue, read at source the same day, for the dollar comparison. 2 Scurion's own published price list (PDF) and its site, read at source, for the ANSI ratings; the same British retailer for the emitter figures; Derek Bristol's published gear reference, read at source, for the quoted explanation. 3 The retailer's own product copy, read at source, for both quoted runtimes; Scurion's own page separately states that capping output gives roughly three to four times the runtime. **The preference for the 900 over the 1500 is a named forum member's recommendation, not a measurement.** 4 The forum's own board statistics and structure, read at source; the National Speleological Society's homepage; the northern regional council's own booking pages for the permit mechanics and the quoted etiquette request; the two named clubs' winch meets as described on their own pages. 5 Scurion's own site for the quoted upgrade offer; the retailer's product copy for the quoted closure specification and the patching price; four forum threads of 2022, 2024 and 2026, read at source, for every quoted owner. **Reddit refused this desk at every route, so no subreddit sentiment appears on any page of this desk.**

THE DEEP END · THE SURVEY INSTRUMENTS

The DiscoX, cave surveying's sharpest instrument, is built by one man

The American market leader stopped production, the Shetland maker suspended his, and a Chinese entrant arrived at €560. All within twelve months.

Four things happened to cave surveying inside a year. The **BRIC5**, the American high-end instrument, ceased production — confirmed by absence: its US retailer's entire survey collection now holds **no instrument at all**, only waterproof paper and books. The **Shetland Attack Pony**, at **£280**, suspended production. **DiscoX** launched into the gap at **£525** and is itself out of stock. And China arrived at **€560**.[1]

These are not companies. **"It's just me doing this,"** wrote the Shetland maker, who has open-sourced the whole project and whose shop now explains he has suspended orders to build a successor. He also notes that a **£28** American tariff must be paid per device, separately, by PayPal, because he has not automated it. The DiscoX maker developed his instrument in public and let the price creep in public too: **"around £450"** in September 2025, then **"I've set the price at £470,"** now £525. He also announced his own mistake — **"I made an error on the PCB by using a 600mA 3.3V regulator for the 500mA laser"** — to the people who had bought one.[2]

The state of the art, assembled, is comic and entirely rational. That **£525** hand-built instrument talks over Bluetooth to a phone running open-source survey software — and the phones are deliberately terrible. **TLH** uses a Galaxy Note bought for about **£20**, because the battery is replaceable. **deck** uses a **£70** Motorola: **"you can always drop it down a tight rift and never see it again."**[3]

A SHORT GLOSSARY

Pitch — a drop you cannot free-climb, so it is rigged with rope.

THE CHATTER · MULU, SON DOONG AND THE PAPERWORK

Both of the region's great trips are a short flight from Changi, and the cheap one has the harder door. **Mulu's own page** prices an overnight at the mouth of the **Sarawak Chamber** — the largest cave chamber on earth — at **MYR 315**. But you must satisfy the Park Manager **in writing**: membership of a recognised caving body, documented experience, or a three-hour unlit wild-cave trip. A **£32** British card is, functionally, the key. **Son Doong** is the opposite — **US$3,000** for six days, **twenty-eight staff for ten guests**, and **2027 and 2028 fully booked**. There is no Singapore caving club; Singapore has no karst.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE RESCUE NUMBERS ACTUALLY SAY

In the British Isles in 2025: **25 caving incidents**, **40 people assisted**, **six injured**, **one underground fatality**, **no helicopter evacuation**. Fifteen of the twenty-five ended with nobody hurt. Across five years the leading cause is not a fall but being **lost or overdue** — 43 against 12 — and the leading injury is **exhaustion or hypothermia**, 19 of 53, the drowning column reading zero. America's long series gives **81 deaths in 28 years**, and its compilers note no rate can be computed because nobody knows the denominator. Caving is not statistically dangerous; it is **logistically unforgiving**. The single death is stated as the report states it: a party heard **"a 'bang' and the rope became taut"**; the cause was unclear, the coroner awaited.[5]

NEXT DESCENTS

Violin making (lutherie) — spruce, maple and a varnish argument three centuries old.

Pigeon racing — electronic clocking, Belgian bloodlines, six hundred miles in a day.

Marquetry & veneer inlay — a knife, a sandbag and the antique-restoration trade behind it.

SOURCES 1 A forum announcement of December 2025, read at source, for the end of BRIC5 production; this desk confirmed the consequence by searching the named US retailer's live survey collection on 15 October 2026 and finding no instrument. The Shetland maker's own shop and the DiscoX maker's own site for both prices and stock statuses; a Chinese vendor's own site for the euro prices. 2 The Shetland maker's shop notice and his 2024 forum posts for the quoted sentence, the open-sourcing, the suspension and the tariff arrangement; the DiscoX maker's posts of September and October 2025 for both quoted prices and the quoted admission. 3 A forum thread of October 2026, usernames and dates as posted. **The only published head-to-head accuracy benchmark is the DiscoX maker's own test of his own device, fourteen legs, one cave, one day; no figure from it is printed.** 4 Mulu National Park's own booking page for the price, group size, age and the three written-evidence conditions; the Vietnamese operator's own pages for the price, staffing and its statement that 2027 and 2028 are fully booked. **The absence of a Singapore club or regional association is the result of a search that found none.** 5 The British Cave Rescue Council's 2025 Incident Report (PDF), read at source in full, for every British figure and the quoted description of the single fatality. **The American figures are read through the standard public compilation of that series, not the original volumes.**

FITNESS · WHITEHALL II

Exercise alone did not cut cognitive risk in Whitehall II

The Whitehall II cohort gives a risk ratio of 0.98 for meeting the guideline. Stacked with diet, no smoking and four vascular targets, it falls to 0.86.

Yuhan Zhang and colleagues reported in *Alzheimer's & Dementia* on **11 October** that eighteen years of meeting the physical-activity guideline, on its own, did almost nothing to the risk of cognitive impairment in the **Whitehall II** cohort. Against a natural-course incidence of **25.5%**, hitting **150 minutes a week** of moderate-to-vigorous activity gave **24.9%** — a risk ratio of **0.98**, confidence interval 0.94 to 1.01. The lower threshold of 75 minutes did the same.[1]

The cohort is unusually relevant here: **3,011** British civil servants, baseline ages **45 to 64**, with a mean of **54.5** — people who began the study at roughly the age of this desk's reader, followed for up to eighteen years. The method is a target trial emulation with a parametric g-formula for time-varying confounding and a thousand bootstrap resamples, which is a serious attempt to get causal shape out of an observational cohort.[1]

Stack the behaviours and the picture changes. Activity with **diet** gave **0.93**; with a normal body-mass index, **0.93**; with diet and not smoking, **0.91**; with all four vascular targets — blood pressure, cholesterol, glucose, BMI — **0.92**. Put together, activity plus diet plus not smoking plus the vascular four produced **21.8%** against 25.5%, a risk ratio of **0.86**, interval 0.79 to 0.93. For a mid-forties trainee that is the argument against treating training as the whole programme.[1]

One combination went the wrong way: activity plus alcohol moderation gave **26.3%**, a ratio of **1.03** — not statistically significant, and worth printing precisely because a paper that reported only its tidy results would have left it out.[1]

0.98 → 0.86

RISK RATIO FOR COGNITIVE IMPAIRMENT OVER EIGHTEEN YEARS: EXERCISE ALONE, THEN EXERCISE PLUS DIET, NOT SMOKING AND FOUR VASCULAR TARGETS[1]

THE CHATTER · THE LONGEVITY ARGUMENT, ATTRIBUTED CAREFULLY

The popular position — three to four hours of cardio a week as a floor, roughly eighty per cent easy and twenty at maximal intensity — reaches this desk through a **listener's written summary** of a podcast, not its subject's own words, and is attributed that way rather than put in his mouth. The pushback is about mechanism. **Chris Masterjohn** has published a flat statement of disinterest in zone-two cardio. A 2026 guide argues the head-to-head human evidence that low-intensity work uniquely builds mitochondria is absent, while making the honest defence that zone two is the most training a person can tolerate, and volume accumulates. **That guide carries no identifiable author, so it is cited as an anonymous argument. Reddit refused this desk entirely.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · THE NULL IS THE WEAKEST PART

Resist the headline. The authors name the problems themselves: a cohort of British civil servants in **relatively good** health; about **73% men**; activity, diet, smoking and alcohol **all self-reported**, which misclassifies exposure and **attenuates** effects toward exactly this kind of null; and impairment defined statistically at **1.5 standard deviations below the cohort mean** rather than clinically, which will include false positives. A null produced by self-reported activity in a healthy-volunteer cohort is the most likely kind of null to be measurement error. The standing objection to the wider field comes from **Eric Topol**: nearly all the outcome data link **fitness measured in METs** on a treadmill, not laboratory VO2 max, and the two have been conflated — **"nearly all the data we have for link to outcomes comes from CRF, not V02 max."** The part a reader can act on: a smartwatch VO2 max figure carries a **7 to 16%** mean absolute percentage error, flattering the unfit. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[13]

SOURCES 1 Zhang Y, Merchant AT, Yang CH, Xu H, Schulz PE, Crump C, Wei J, "Physical activity and combinations with modifiable factors and risk of cognitive impairment: the Whitehall II study," *Alzheimer's & Dementia: TRCI* 2026;12(4):e70307, 11 October 2026, read at source in full: the sample, baseline ages, follow-up, the target-trial method, and every incidence, risk ratio and interval quoted, including the non-significant alcohol combination. The limitations are the authors' own. **Risk differences and case counts are not reported in the paper and none is printed. The study has no secondary coverage anywhere; it is the paper or nothing.** 2 A reader's published summary of a podcast, attributed to the summariser and not to its subject; a named nutrition writer's published post; and an unsigned 2026 training guide, cited as unsigned. **Reddit was unreachable by every route tried and the Singapore forum's fitness board returned 404, so no community sentiment is sourced on this desk.** 3 Eric Topol, "The Flawed V02 Max Craze," 23 February 2026, read at source, for the quoted sentence and the wearable error range. **It is dated outside this week's window and used as a standing objection, not as news. The piece is self-published; its citations are checkable and were spot-checked.**

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

Esplanade runs 29 free shows; Tokyo's private museums publish no price

Two Singapore festivals and two Tokyo national museums print full tiered fares. Ten of twenty-six listings below give no figure at all.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

1–30 OCT ★ **Popaholic 2026**
ESPLANADE · **29 SHOWS, EVERY ONE FREE** · TONIGHT *HELLO, ZALELO*; 22 OCT *THE RABBIT HOLE* · SUITS A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD[1]

18 OCT **Writers Festival early bird closes**
SUNDAY · **FESTIVAL PASS $24 BECOMES $30; YOUTH PASS $12 BECOMES $15**, BOTH EXCLUDING BOOKING FEE[2]

21 OCT **Junior and the Holiday Magic**
TO 21 NOV · DRAMA CENTRE THEATRE · **NO PRICE PUBLISHED**, BOX OFFICE CLOSED · NO AGE RANGE STATED[3]

13–22 NOV ★ **Singapore Writers Festival 2026**
VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE, NATIONAL GALLERY · **THE FESTIVAL WARNS OF A FRAUDULENT EMAIL IN ITS DIRECTOR'S NAME — BUY ONLY THROUGH OFFICIAL CHANNELS**[2]

18–22 NOV **Rafta Rafta**
ESPLANADE · **FROM $57.20** · BEGINS TWO DAYS BEFORE KALAA UTSAVAM'S OWN STATED OPENING[1]

20–29 NOV ★ **Kalaa Utsavam 2026**
ESPLANADE · NEARLY ALL PRICED — *SONGS OF THE BULBUL* **$39.60**, *INVENTIONS* **$41.50** · **PAATI'S SPICE KITCHEN $40, THE ONLY LISTING TAGGED FAMILY** · SACHIN–JIGAR: NO DATE, NO PRICE[1]

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

17 OCT **Tokyo film festival tickets open**
TOMORROW, STAGGERED — 10:00 ANIMATION AND YOUTH, 14:00 GALA, **16:00 COMPETITION** · **TWO TICKETS MAXIMUM**[4]

26 OCT ★ **39th Tokyo International Film Festival**
TO 4 NOV · HIBIYA AND GINZA · OPENING AND CLOSING **¥3,500 / ¥2,700** STUDENT; COMPETITION **¥2,200** · THEATRE BOX OFFICES DO NOT SELL THESE[4]

14 OCT **Daitokuji: A Zen Temple Beyond Compare**
TO 6 DEC · TOKYO NATIONAL MUSEUM · **¥2,300 ADULT, FREE BELOW JUNIOR-HIGH AGE** · **ADVANCE SALES CLOSED ON THE 13TH**[5]

27 OCT **Shojo Manga Infinity advance sales close**
NATIONAL ART CENTER, ROPPONGI · RUNS 28 OCT–8 FEB · **¥2,000 ADVANCE / ¥2,200 AFTER; UNDER-16S FREE**[6]

31 OCT **Roppongi Art Night 2026**
TO 1 NOV · THE MORI ART MUSEUM CONFIRMS IT OPENS TO **6AM** · STREET PROGRAMME REPORTED FREE, **BUT THE FESTIVAL'S OWN SITE SERVED NO CONTENT** · NOT A CHILD'S NIGHT PAST NINE[7]

30 OCT **HAIKYU!! Challengers**
TO 11 JAN · MORI ARTS CENTER GALLERY, A SEPARATE VENUE · **NO PRICE PUBLISHED** · THE OBVIOUS PICK IF SHE READS MANGA[7]

10 of 23

LISTINGS IN THIS AGENDA THAT PUBLISH NO PRICE AT ALL AT THE PRIMARY SOURCE — THE WITHHOLDERS NOW CONCENTRATED IN THEATRE AND PRIVATE-MUSEUM ART[8]

PLANNING NOTES · WHAT ACTUALLY BINDS

Two deadlines inside a fortnight. Sunday **18 October**: the Writers Festival early bird ends and a Youth Pass goes from $12 to $15. Monday **27 October**: advance tickets close for Shojo Manga, after which the price rises ¥200 a head. And **tomorrow at ten**, Tokyo's festival opens general sales with a two-ticket cap, Competition last at four. **For a twelve-year-old** the value this month is startling: Popaholic is free for a month, Daitokuji free below junior-high age, Shojo Manga free under sixteen, the Youth Pass $12 until Sunday. **Dropped on the still-on check:** an entire Singapore concert calendar — the ticketing agent returned 403, the listings platform rendered zero results, a promoter 503 — so nothing from it is listed, including shows advertised as on sale. **Hong Kong is dropped entirely.**[8]

SOURCES Every event was re-verified against a promoter, venue, festival or official ticketing page before printing; those that failed are named in the planning note and are not listed. 1 The venue's own festival pages for Popaholic, Kalaa Utsavam and Voices, each read at source, for dates, the free status, every per-show price, the FAMILY tag and the date discrepancy. **Of Kalaa Utsavam's sixteen ticketed listings, twelve rendered with prices; the headline act carries none.** 2 The festival's own site and passes page, read at source, for both tiers, both early-bird prices, the 18 October deadline and the fraud warning. 3 The theatre company's own site, read at source, for both productions and the absence of price or age guidance. 4 The film festival's own site and both ticket pages, read at source, for dates, the staggered sale times, the price tiers and the two-ticket limit. **Other sections' prices are not published.** 5 The museum's own exhibition page, read at source. 6 The gallery's own English exhibition page, read at source. 7 The Mori Art Museum's own page, read at source, confirming the all-night opening and the gallery dates. **The street programme's free status is reported by two listings outlets, not the festival, whose site returned a title and no content twice.** 8 **The excluded concert calendar was checked at its primary sellers: the main ticketing agent returned 403, the national listings platform rendered zero results, a promoter returned 503 twice, and a second platform was unreachable. A barred artist recorded in the events ledger does not appear here.**

THE TABLE · FIVE NEW OPENINGS

A Telok Ayer gelato kiosk has reopened on Amoy Street

The kiosk that was AiFOKATO now does a twelve-combination affogato at $10. Three of this week's five have one review apiece.

AiFOKATO has graduated. The viral Telok Ayer takeaway kiosk is now a sit-down café at 97 Amoy Street, built as a *hanok* — a traditional Korean house — with skylit rooms. The format is the draw: a **do-it-yourself affogato at $10**, one of four gelati under one of three hot pours, which is twelve combinations. The **Gelato Shakerato at $9** and the whole coffee list are exclusive to this outlet. Eatbook, on **7 October**, liked the vanilla and the chocolate affogato and found the matcha gelato **"melted incredibly fast"** and the butter mochi **"chewy and slightly starchy."** That visit was a media tasting. Not halal-certified. Walk in; the weekend close at 10.30pm is the move.[1]

Tandem Co is a coverage story rather than an opening — HungryGoWhere reviewed it **yesterday**, but it opened in **June**. It is a neighbourhood bakery-café on a quiet landed stretch of Jalan Tua Kong in Siglap. Co-founder **Keith Chua**, 23, was a barista at Boronas, which vacated this very unit in May. The **shio pan at $4.50** and the garlic cream-cheese version at **$5.80** were the reviewer's picks; the cinnamon rolls were **"a little dry."** It is **Muslim-owned and the ice cream is halal-certified** — the review does not say the whole menu is, and neither does this desk.[2]

Yogeek, on Haji Lane, builds its frozen yoghurt on a **Greek** base and sells it by weight at **$4.50 per 100g**. Eatbook rated it **8 out of 10** and was specific about both halves: it prefers Yogeek's tangier yoghurt to the incumbent's while conceding the incumbent gives more toppings for less, and lists among its cons **"quite pricey"** and a mango **"somewhat watery and soft."** A plain Original came to **$11.33**. One figure to treat carefully: protein is **10.4g per 150g** at one outlet and **9.8g** at another, both crediting the brand. Despite the Kampong Glam address it is **not halal-certified**.[3]

Two more, with their thinness declared. **Shi Tang by Mahota Kitchen** opened in Prime Court on Yishun Avenue 6 doing *zi char*, fish-head steamboat from **$38** to **$88**, fish from a farm off Pulau Tekong — and the useful detail is sceptical: staff told the reviewer only the **whole fish and the steamboat** are guaranteed farm-fresh. **Rogs Race**, under twenty seats at Tanjong Pagar, is matcha by day and beer from five; founder **Bryant Tan**, 28, named it with an anagram of his mother's and grandmother's names. The reviewer found the house espresso drink **acidic**.[4]

AFFOGATO $10 · SHIO PAN $4.50 · $4.50 / 100G · STEAMBOAT FROM $38 · MATCHA $7.90

THE BUZZ · WHAT IS ACTUALLY KNOWN

Three of these five are reviewed by a single outlet apiece, and this desk will not dress that up. **Tandem Co** has exactly one review anywhere, published yesterday; **Shi Tang** and **Rogs Race** one each. **AiFOKATO** and **Yogeek** have three and two — and both visits were media tastings, so the food was very likely complimentary. **Burpple returned 403 and Reddit refused every route**, so the only non-press sentiment anywhere was a pair of Lemon8 posts on AiFOKATO reporting servings **"kinda small."** This is a quiet week in Singapore dining, and a quiet week is allowed to read as one.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT GOT DROPPED, AND WHY

Sansok was researched and dropped a second consecutive issue. It has the best pedigree on any list this month — opened by **Min Yohan** of *Culinary Class Wars* — but it ran here in No. 125 and everything since is a listing, not a review. An entry in a round-up is not a new peg. **Nice Noodle** went the same way: its only coverage calls a dish **"the one everyone's going to talk about,"** a prediction rather than a verdict. **Taste Ipoh** opened in **December 2025**. Seven further venues are barred under this desk's repetition rules.[6]

SOURCES 1 A Singapore food title's first-look review, Edna Low, 7 October 2026, read at source, for the format, both prices, the exclusive menu, both quoted criticisms, the halal status and the hours; a second food title and a lifestyle title as corroborating coverage. **The first states its visit was a media tasting.** 2 HungryGoWhere, Angeline Ang, 15 October 2026, read at source, for the June opening, the co-founder, the previous tenants, both prices, both criticisms, the ownership and the certification. **This is the only coverage of this venue anywhere; the halal certification is stated for the ice cream only.** 3 A food title's review, Isaiah De En Gan, 23 September, for the rating, the price by weight, the comparison, both cons, the bill and the halal statement; a second title for the differing protein figure. **Both credit the brand and disagree; both are printed. The first was a media tasting and says one topping was not tasted.** 4 HungryGoWhere, Evan Mua, 15 October, and a further report of 12 October, both read at source. 5 As above. **Burpple returned 403 and Reddit was unreachable, so no forum sentiment was obtained; the two Lemon8 comments came through a search layer.** 6 Each dropped venue was researched and rejected on stated rules: a second run without a new peg; coverage that is a prediction, not a review; an opening ten months old; and one for which no source exists. **The rest are recorded in this desk's ledger as spent or too recently run.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · TAIWAN

Taiwan recognised the Siraya in July; 1,336 people have registered

Taiwan's Council of Indigenous Peoples projected 50,000 in the first year; its own 2022 estimate of plains-Indigenous ancestry was 980,000.

On **30 July 2026** Taiwan's Executive Yuan recognised the **Siraya** as the island's seventeenth Indigenous people — the first of the **"plains"** groups ever admitted, after a campaign of more than thirty years and a unanimous Constitutional Court judgment in 2022 that gave the legislature three years to act. Registration opened on **13 August**. By the end of September the Council of Indigenous Peoples told the Legislative Yuan that **12,178 people had applied** and **1,336 had completed registration**.[1]

Set that against two other numbers and the story appears. The Council had projected about **50,000** registrations in the first year. And its own 2022 estimate of how many people in Taiwan carry plains-Indigenous ancestry was **980,000** — roughly one Taiwanese in twenty-four. The gap between 980,000 and 1,336 is not indifference. It is a price signal, and three things set the price.[2]

The first is that the evidence test is a colonial archive. Article 8 accepts **Japanese-era household records** as proof of membership, and the implementing regulation specifies records from **before 1945**, for the applicant or a direct lineal ancestor. In practice that means finding a register in which a Japanese census-taker wrote the character **熟** — *shú*, "cooked," the administrative opposite of "raw" — beside a great-grandmother's name. You are Indigenous in 2026 if a colonial clerk thought your ancestors had assimilated in 1935.[3]

> ***You are Indigenous in 2026 if a colonial clerk thought your ancestors had assimilated in 1935.***

The second is that recognition arrived without rights. On **15 October** the Council confirmed that only **three statutes** apply directly to the newly recognised: the Indigenous Languages Development Act, the Cultural Heritage Preservation Act, and the law protecting Indigenous traditional intellectual creations. Article 23 instructs the government merely to **"consider"** legislating on political participation, land, health and welfare **within three years**; **118 laws** are queued.[4]

Three days ago the Siraya held their first night ceremony as a recognised people. At **Jibeishua** in Dongshan, Tainan, on **13 October**, a newly chosen *wang-i* — the female ritual leader — presided over the pig-selection rite with bamboo orchid and rice wine. **Seventeen** members made offerings with **seventeen pigs**, which those present read as a lucky echo of the seventeenth people.[5]

Behind the Siraya stand nine more applications — the Taivoan, Makatao, Taokas, Kaxabu, Pazeh, Papora, Babuza and Ketagalan among them, three already at the expert panel. Scholars and activists put the number who could plausibly claim at **250,000 to 350,000**. If recognition on these terms is what awaits them, the state has found a way to say yes to a million people at the price of a language subsidy.[6]

The third is that the largest prize is constitutionally locked. The six reserved Indigenous seats in the Legislative Yuan — three plains, three mountain — sit in Article 4 of the Additional Articles of the Constitution. Moving them requires a constitutional amendment, the highest bar in Taiwanese politics. Alongside them sit **56** plains-Indigenous county and city council seats.[2]

3 of 118

STATUTES THAT APPLY DIRECTLY TO TAIWAN'S NEWLY RECOGNISED PLAINS INDIGENOUS PEOPLES, AGAINST THE LAWS QUEUED FOR AMENDMENT BEFORE THEY HOLD FULL RIGHTS[4]

SOURCES 1 Taiwan's central news agency and two Taipei dailies, each read at source on 14 and 15 October 2026, reporting the Council of Indigenous Peoples' briefing to the Legislative Yuan: the application and registration figures as at end-September. **Three independent outlets give the same two numbers; the Council's own site publishes no registration statistics this desk could find. The Executive Yuan approval is dated 30 July by four outlets and 31 July by a fifth; the majority date is printed.** 2 A Taipei daily of 27 June 2022, read at source, for the chairman's ancestry estimate and the seat counts; a Taipei daily of October 2026 for the first-year projection. 3 The Act and its implementing regulation, both read at source in the Ministry of Justice's database. **That the records are those marked 熟 is the uniform account of the Taiwanese press and a long-form report on the campaign; the statutes say "Japanese-era household records" without naming the character, and this desk has not read the gazette notice that would settle the test exactly.** 4 The Council's own statement of 15 October 2026, read at source, naming the three statutes that apply and confirming that ritual-leave does not; Article 23 for the three-year instruction; a Taipei daily of 14 October for the 118 laws. 5 A Taipei daily of 13 October 2026, read at source, for the ceremony, the ritual leader, the pig count and the timings. 6 The central news agency and a Taipei daily for the nine applicant groups; the claimant estimate from an environmental news service, attributed to scholars and activists.

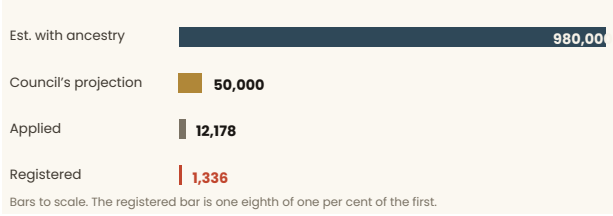
Taiwan has run this experiment before, and used the result as proof that the people did not exist. Between **1956 and 1963** the provincial government opened four brief windows in which anyone whose household register read 熟, and who lived on the plains, could register as Indigenous. Almost nobody did — stigma was heavy and notification poor. The **1956** document omitted Tainan County altogether, which is where most Siraya live. Officials subsequently treated the resulting non-registration as the Siraya having **"voluntarily relinquished"** their status, and that reading stood for half a century.[1]

A low take-up produced by administrative failure became the state's evidence of assimilation. That is the precise risk the figure of 1,336 now carries, and it is why the number matters more than it looks. In 2013 a Tainan registration drive found about **20,000** people with 熟 in their Japanese-era records; roughly **11,000** said they were willing to register; **fewer than 3,000** actually changed their records. Each step down that staircase is friction, and friction is policy by other means.[1]

A low take-up produced by administrative failure became the state's evidence of assimilation.

There is a closer precedent still, and it is the one that should settle the argument. In **January 2007** Taiwan recognised the **Sakizaya** as its thirteenth Indigenous people. About **20,000** people had signed in support of that recognition. By 2022, **1,043** had registered. As of July this year — **nineteen years on** — the count stands at **1,237**. Taiwan has already learned what a recognised people with few attached rights registers at, and the Siraya's 1,336 is tracking the Sakizaya almost exactly.[2]

Compare a jurisdiction that attached money. Canada amended the Indian Act in **1985** to restore status to people stripped of it by discriminatory provisions, and to their children. More than **100,000 people** were added to the register. Where restored status came with treaty entitlements, band membership and transfer payments, uptake ran into six figures within a decade — and the fight moved immediately to the two-tier structure the amendment itself created. Taiwan has produced the two-tier structure without the uptake, because it has produced it without the entitlements.[3]



What recognition was expected to reach, and what it reached. *Meridian* original, from the Council of Indigenous Peoples' own figures.[4]

The fiscal logic is visible once you lay the statutes side by side. What recognition currently buys is language protection, cultural-heritage protection and a traditional-name registry — funded from existing budgets. What it does not buy is the reserved legislative and council seats, reserved-land inheritance and transfer rights, the Indigenous track in the civil-service examination, statutory employment quotas, scholarship guarantees, the university-entrance bonus, or the paid ritual-leave day the Council expressly confirmed does not apply. **The three statutes that do apply are the three that cost least.**[5]

100,000+

PEOPLE ADDED TO CANADA'S INDIAN REGISTER AFTER THE 1985 AMENDMENT, WHERE RESTORED STATUS CARRIED TREATY ENTITLEMENTS AND TRANSFER PAYMENTS[3]

0

COMPANIES FINED OR SUED UNDER SINGAPORE'S TRANSBOUNDARY HAZE POLLUTION ACT IN THE TWELVE YEARS SINCE IT TOOK EFFECT (P5)

1,237

SAKIZAYA REGISTERED AS OF JULY 2026, NINETEEN YEARS AFTER TAIWAN RECOGNISED THEM; ABOUT 20,000 HAD SIGNED IN SUPPORT OF THAT RECOGNITION[2]

SOURCES 1 A Taipei daily's long feature of 9 August 2026 and an independent Taiwanese investigative outlet's report on the Siraya constitutional case, both read at source, for the four registration windows and their years, the omission of Tainan County from the 1956 document, the quoted official construction placed on the resulting non-registration, and the 2013 Tainan drive's three figures. 2 The Council of Indigenous Peoples' own population figures for the Sakizaya as at July 2026, reached through the standard public compilation of them, with the 2007 recognition date and the 2022 count; the figure of about 20,000 signatures in support of that recognition from the investigative outlet cited above, read at source. **The Council's own per-group statistics page returned an error twice to this desk, so the current Sakizaya count is read through that compilation rather than from the Council directly.** 3 The Canadian register's own published history, read at source, for the 1985 amendment and the figure of more than 100,000 people added. **This figure is read through a general reference work rather than from the Canadian government's own statistics, and is the least securely sourced number on this page; it is used for the order of magnitude and the direction of the comparison, not for precision.** 4 Figures as sourced on p21: the ancestry estimate from the Council chairman in 2022, the first-year projection from a Taipei daily, and the application and registration counts from the Council's October 2026 briefing. 5 The Act and its implementing regulation, read at source; the Council's own statement of 15 October 2026 confirming that the seasonal-ritual leave entitlement does not apply; the contested entitlements as enumerated by the then Council chairman in his 2022 objection, read at source.

The objection from inside the recognised sixteen is not bigotry, and it should be stated at its strongest. Taiwan's existing Indigenous population is about **629,000** — some **2.7%** of the country, growing **2.9%** a year. The entitlements attached to that status are a fixed pool: reserved land, examination quotas, employment guarantees, scholarships, and the seats. Adding a million people to the pool divides it. The then chairman of the Council of Indigenous Peoples, himself Indigenous, made exactly that argument in 2022, and named the **3** legislative and **56** council seats as what was at stake. The second tier exists because somebody did that arithmetic.[1]

The objection from the Pingpu side is that this is recognition as demotion. A youth-alliance writer calls the Act **一族三制** — "one people, three systems" — a category created outside the Indigenous Peoples Basic Act, producing legally restricted subjects with the state still drawing the boundary. More than forty Indigenous organisations opposed a separate statute in May 2025 and wanted the existing status law amended instead. A lawyer writing in October 2025 pointed at the sharpest edge: the already-recognised **Kavalan** could be split, siblings in one household ending with different rights to education, employment and healthcare depending on whether an ancestor once filled in a form.[2]

Siblings in one household, with different rights, depending on whether an ancestor filled in a form.

And the honest counter-argument to this whole essay is that **1,336** may simply be administrative lag. The roll runs to **12 August 2031**, the period is extendable once, and supplementary applications are allowed afterwards. Two months is nothing. That objection deserves its hearing — and the Sakizaya answer it, because nineteen years is not lag. When Taiwan last recognised a people and attached almost nothing to it, the register settled near a thousand and stayed there.[3]

Which leaves the argument this desk thinks is actually being made, and it is not really about Taiwan. Taiwan has spent a decade telling the world it is an Austronesian island rather than a Chinese one; Indigeneity is load-bearing for the national story, and it is a good story, honestly told. But when its own Constitutional Court ordered it to admit the plains peoples, the state built them a second tier: a name, a roll, a ritual calendar and a language subsidy, with the seats, the land, the quotas and even the paid day off deferred to a review. That is not a failure of good faith. It is a discovery — that there is a version of recognition which costs almost nothing, and that it can be offered at scale.[4]

The register is the receipt. **Twelve thousand one hundred and seventy-eight** people thought the offer was worth filling in a form for. **One thousand three hundred and thirty-six** completed it. Nine more peoples are in the queue behind them, and the terms are now set. When the *Financial Times* writes this up, the number will be larger and the shape will be the same.[3]

WHAT THE ARGUMENT LOOKS LIKE AT HOME

On Taiwan's largest public forum the July recognition threads read as partisan suspicion rather than as a debate about Indigenous justice. The dominant framing is that recognition is a ruling-party project, since Siraya territory is concentrated in Tainan; a second strand disputes bloodline, holding that the Siraya survive only as a place name; and a third — the revealing one — is resentment about benefits. Commenters joke about examination bonus points, subsidies and pensions. **Every one of those entitlements is a thing the statute withholds.** The public quarrel is being conducted entirely about rights that were not granted. Against that, the community's own register is ceremonial and not fiscal at all: seventeen pigs, a new ritual leader, and a procession that ran until three in the morning. **These are summarised Taiwanese forum comments, reported as reported, not verified claims.**[5]

SOURCES 1 Taiwan's public broadcaster and an environmental news service, both read at source, for the registered Indigenous population at end-2025, its share of the population and its annual growth; a Taipei daily of 27 June 2022, read at source, for the then Council chairman's objection and the seat counts he named. 2 An opinion piece by a writer for the Central Pingpu Indigenous Youth Alliance, published 7 November 2025 and read at source, for the quoted phrase and the argument; a lawyer-commentator's piece of 6 October 2025, read at source in republication, for the Kavalan split; the opposition of more than forty Indigenous organisations in May 2025 as reported by the environmental news service, read at source. 3 The Executive Yuan gazette notice, read at source, for the registration window closing 12 August 2031; the Act, read at source, for the extension and supplementary-application provisions; the Sakizaya comparison as sourced on p22. 4 The author's argument, resting on the sourced facts above. **It is an argument, and is offered as one.** 5 Two threads on Taiwan's largest public bulletin board, July 2026, read at source and summarised rather than quoted. **These are anonymous forum comments characterised in this desk's own words and attributed as reported sentiment, not as verified claims about anyone's motives.** The ceremony detail is sourced on p21. **THE NEGATIVE CHECK, stated in full: this desk searched for prior coverage of the Siraya registration gap in the New York Times, BBC, Reuters, the Financial Times, The Economist, Bloomberg and The Guardian, by named-outlet search, by site-restricted search, and by direct fetch of three of those outlets' own search pages. It found none — no feature, and no story. The English-language coverage that does exist is Taiwanese or specialist. Three of the seven outlets' search pages refused this desk outright, and the search tool declined a domain-filtered query across all seven, so the check is thorough rather than exhaustive.**

MERIDIAN

THE LAST WORD

Somebody owned the orphan

A Singapore-flagged container ship is on the bottom of the Strait of Hormuz. Her flag state will say only that she was hit by “unknown projectiles”; Iran says she struck a mine; no one has said they fired (p3). Eleven days of smoke have sat over Singapore, the index has passed the number the Government itself published, and in twelve years not one company has been fined (p5). Ukrainian drones lost their satellite uplink mid-war and the White House, the Pentagon and SpaceX each point somewhere else (p4).

The pattern runs deeper than the news desks. The luxury tap is a Hungarian cartridge in a body somebody else machined (p6), and Taiwan has recognised a people on terms so light that of 980,000 possible claimants, 1,336 have registered (p21). None of this is conspiracy: it is what large systems do when authorship is expensive. A claim of responsibility invites a reprisal; a named arsonist invites a prosecution proved across a border; a published rung invites being held to it.

Which is why the quote on page two is a standard and not a joke. Kennedy used the old line about a hundred fathers on the day he took sole responsibility for a failure that had several. The useful question is not who is hiding — mostly it is obvious — but what it costs a system to make someone sign. In Britain, sixteen volunteer cave-rescue teams gave 5,570 unpaid hours last year and logged every incident, including their one death, in a public document that says plainly where the cause is still unknown (p17). Nobody made them. It is what putting your name to something looks like when you have decided to.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 134 · 16 October 2026

SOURCES A note on method. This edition’s load-bearing figures were read where they are published: a port authority’s own release on two of its ships; an environment agency’s machine feed, queried directly at five in the morning; a central bank’s policy statement; a foundry’s filing and its own earnings call; a chipmaker’s research page, including the benchmark that undercuts its own claim; a brass mill’s alloy datasheet; a cave-rescue council’s full incident report; and Taiwan’s statute database. Where a host refused us — **Reddit to every desk for a second issue running; Metacritic; Hodinkee and Watchuseek; Singapore’s main ticketing agent; and PUB’s live pages** — the page says so rather than quietly sourcing around it. One correction to No. 133 is printed on p3.